

Mastery English (C2 Proficiency)

Your English notebook for the whole course. Refine nuance, pragmatics and style, write and speak with authority, and track what you can do.

8 modules • 24 lessons

Words • grammar • speaking • I can...

Name: _____

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The Mot Juste — Precision & Nuance

Three lessons on choosing exactly. First the single word: its connotation, its force, and the company it habitually keeps. Then the whole manner of a message: register as a mixing desk, with tone as a dial of its own. Finally the ready-made chunks that proficient speakers retrieve whole, in a fixed order and with a fixed partner, and that betray a speaker the moment they are slightly wrong.

Lessons 1.1–1.3

Classes C1–C3

Level C2

Name: _____

HOW THIS MODULE WORKS

Each heading tells you what to do: **Read and say**, **Listen**, **Write**, **With a partner** or **Self-check**. Few tasks here have a single right answer. What matters is that your choice is precise, natural, appropriate to its reader, and that you can say *why* you made it.

When a task draws on your own experience, you decide what to share. Use your real life, **or** a new identity card, **or** something you invent. All three are equally good. In role-plays you play the card, not yourself, and you can always say "Pass."

◆ WELCOME TO C2

You have long since been able to say what you mean in English. At C2 the question is rarely "Which word is correct?" and almost always "Which word is *exactly* right?" Progress now looks like refinement: a hundred small calibrations rather than one large leap. Expect feedback on four things throughout the course: **precision** (the exact word), **naturalness** (what a proficient user would actually say), **appropriacy** (whether a choice suits the reader and the room) and **effect** (whether it does what you intend).

◆ FIRST-DAY WRITING SAMPLE – WRITE (8 MINUTES)

This is not a test. It helps your teacher see where your English is already masterful and where it is merely very good. Write **100–150 words** without a dictionary or phone. Choose **one** prompt.

A. Describe a place, an object or a daily routine you know well (real or invented) so precisely that a reader who has never encountered it can see, hear and judge it.

B. A project you are involved in (real or invented) will be delayed by a month. Write the news twice: first as a short email to a senior colleague, then as a two-line message to a close friend.

My prompt: ☐ A ☐ B

◆ READ AND SAY – NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

the mot juste

denotation

connotation

a near-synonym

a cline

force

specificity

semantic prosody

loaded

pejorative

overwritten

to weigh a word

Pairs worth separating:

frugal / stingy

resolute / obstinate

self-assured / cocky

inquisitive / nosy

distinctive / peculiar

childlike / childish

bemused / amused

startled / taken aback

trudge / amble / stride

bring about / cause

denotation = a word's literal, dictionary meaning · **connotation** = the associations and value judgment it carries · **semantic prosody** = the favorable or unfavorable aura a word acquires from the company it habitually keeps · **a cline** = a scale of gradual differences

◆ GRAMMAR BOX

One fact, three verdicts.

Neutral	Positive	Negative
careful with money	thrifty, frugal	stingy, tight-fisted, miserly
determined	resolute, tenacious	stubborn, obstinate, pig-headed
confident	self-assured, poised	cocky, arrogant, smug
unusual	distinctive, singular	odd, peculiar, weird

No true synonyms. Near-synonyms differ in at least one dimension.

Force	tepid → warm → hot → scorching · decent → good → excellent → superb → sublime
Register	kids → children → offspring · try → attempt → endeavor
Specificity	walk → stride, amble, trudge, saunter · look → glance, peer, scrutinize
Collocation	startled <i>by a noise</i> · taken aback <i>by his rudeness</i> · astonished <i>at the sheer scale</i>
Careful senses	<i>bemused</i> = bewildered, not amused · <i>fulsome</i> praise = excessive, insincere · <i>enormity</i> = great wickedness

Semantic prosody. *set in* keeps unpleasant company (rot, despair, winter), so "happiness set in" jars. *cause* leans negative (damage, delay, concern), so a success is better *brought about*. Likewise *utterly* (ruined), *bordering on* (rudeness), *rife with* (corruption), *a spate of* (burglaries), *a breeding ground for* (resentment).

Precision is not ornament. The mot juste is often the plain, specific word. *She trudged home* beats *she walked slowly and wearily*; *use* usually beats *utilize*.

◆ LISTEN – EXERCISE 1: TWO REFERENCES FOR ONE COLLEAGUE

Your teacher reads two descriptions of the same colleague, Dana: one by an admirer, one by a critic. The facts are identical; the words are not. Write the word each speaker uses.

	The admirer says Dana is...	The critic says Dana is...
1. with money	_____	_____
2. once decided	_____	_____
3. in meetings	_____	_____

4. with questions	_____	_____
5. when giving opinions	_____	_____
6. about details	_____	_____
7. in style	_____	_____

With a partner: which critic's word is the most damaging, and why?

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 2: CONNOTATION SORT

Label each word positive (+), neutral (0) or negative (-). Be ready to defend a borderline case.

1. inquisitive _____ curious _____ nosy _____ prying _____
2. assertive _____ forceful _____ pushy _____ domineering _____
3. traditional _____ old-fashioned _____ dated _____ classic _____
4. youthful _____ childlike _____ childish _____ immature _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 3: UP THE CLINE

Order each set from weakest to strongest. Then circle any word you would not use in a formal report.

1. furious · irritated · livid · annoyed
→ _____
2. scorching · warm · tepid · hot
→ _____
3. detest · dislike · am not keen on · loathe
→ _____
4. superb · decent · sublime · good · excellent
→ _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 4: ONE EXACT WORD

Replace the words in **bold** with one more precise word. Many answers are defensible; judge by manner and register.

1. "Fine," she **said unwillingly and resentfully**. _____
2. "You're late again," he **said with mild, weary reproach**. _____
3. "We won!" they **said with sudden loud joy**. _____
4. After the double shift, he **walked slowly and heavily** home. _____
5. She **looked quickly** at her watch. _____
6. The children **ate very fast and hungrily** the whole pizza. _____

7. The inspector **looked very carefully and critically** at the accounts. _____

8. On Sunday we **walked in a slow, relaxed way** along the river. _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 5: SPOT THE PROSODY CLASH

One word or phrase in each sentence keeps the wrong company. Underline it and replace it.

1. Her tireless campaigning finally caused a landmark victory.

→ _____

2. A wonderful sense of calm set in across the valley.

→ _____

3. The new director's arrival was a breeding ground for fresh ideas.

→ _____

4. The volunteer center was rife with cheerful helpers.

→ _____

5. The team has enjoyed a spate of awards this year.

→ _____

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: TUNING ONE SENTENCE

Lena: Could you look at the opening line of my review? "The restaurant was very good and the food was nice."

Omar: It's accurate. It's also utterly forgettable. What was actually good about it?

Lena: The service was quick without feeling rushed, and the soup was astonishing.

Omar: Then say that. "Attentive, unhurried service" does more than "very good."

Lena: And the prices? I wrote "cheap."

Omar: Careful. "Cheap" can suggest poor quality. Do you want "reasonably priced" or "a bargain"?

Lena: "A bargain," I think. What about "The dessert was sublime, magnificent and transcendent"?

Omar: Now you've overwritten it. Choose one. The strongest word works best alone.

Lena: "Sublime," then. It sounds a little grand, but it was a remarkable dessert.

Omar: Then it has earned its place. That's the test: does the word serve, or does it show off?

Underline every change Omar suggests. Which dimension does each one improve: force, connotation, register, specificity or prosody?

◆ WITH A PARTNER – MOT JUSTE EDITING WORKSHOP

Your group receives a deliberately vague text. Tune it: at least **ten** substitutions, including at least one gain each in force, connotation, specificity and register. Do not add or change any facts. Log four of your changes.

Original	Our choice	Dimension	Why

Justify or cut. Swap texts with another group. Their skeptic may challenge up to three changes: "Does this serve or show off?" Name the dimension and defend it in one sentence, or cut it. One change we reverted, and why:

One strength (quote it)	
One suggestion (quote it)	

◆ SELF-CHECK – CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

Which word means "puzzled, bewildered" rather than "amused"?

A) astonished

B) bemused

C) startled

2

Semantic prosody explains why which sentence sounds subtly wrong?

A) A deep contentment set in.

B) A cold, damp winter set in.

C) Rot had set in.

3

"The chair thanked the speaker in fulsome terms." In its careful sense, the praise was...

A) generous and entirely sincere

B) excessive, perhaps insincere

C) brief and formal

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ distinguish denotation from connotation and choose a positive, neutral or negative near-synonym on purpose
- ◆ ☐ order near-synonyms by force and explain what else separates them
- ◆ ☐ use *bemused*, *fulsome* and *enormity* in their careful senses
- ◆ ☐ hear and repair a semantic prosody clash
- ◆ ☐ replace a weak word plus a modifier with one exact word, without overwriting

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Choose a pair of near-synonyms you used to treat as interchangeable. Write one sentence where only one of them fits, and one sentence explaining why.

◆ READ AND SAY – NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

register field tenor mode the formality cline frozen tone deferential

authoritative a register clang code-switching jargon an archaism

Notice is hereby given that... Please be advised that... failing which... without further notice

Just a reminder that... Heads up, Bear with me one moment. Hang on a sec.

I see it a bit differently. I must respectfully take issue with...

field = what the text is about · **tenor** = the relationship between the people (power and distance) · **mode** = spoken or written, planned or spontaneous · **a clang** = one marker that belongs to a different register

◆ GRAMMAR BOX

One message, five levels. The fact stays the same; everything else moves together.

1 • Frozen	Notice is hereby given that the premises will close at 3:00 p.m. on Friday, June 12.
2 • Formal	Please be advised that the community center will close early on Friday.
3 • Neutral	Just a reminder that we're closing at 3 on Friday.
4 • Informal	Heads up, we're shutting early Friday.
5 • Intimate	Friday, 3 o'clock, doors shut. Don't be late!

Markers of HIGH register	Latinate words (<i>ascertain, remuneration</i>) · nominalization · passive and impersonal (<i>It was decided that...</i>) · hedging · long, subordinated sentences · no contractions · <i>furthermore, notwithstanding, thereby</i>
Markers of LOW register	phrasal verbs (<i>sort out, put off</i>) · contractions and ellipsis (<i>Got a minute?</i>) · <i>you know, I mean, anyway</i> · vague language (<i>stuff, sort of</i>) · idiom and slang · direct address and tags (<i>...right?</i>)

Tone is a second dial. Formality sets the ceremony; tone sets the attitude. Same level, opposite tone:

Warm	Thanks so much for flagging this; it's really helpful. I'll get it fixed today and let you know the moment it's done.
Cool	Noted. This will be addressed in due course. You will be informed upon completion.

Other tones: **ironic** (over-grand language on a trivial subject), **authoritative** (boosters, imperatives, no hedging), **deferential** (hedges, questions, *I wonder if...*).

Move the whole cluster. One stray marker produces a clang: "Please find attached the aforementioned pics." Over-formality (*utilize, commence, endeavor*) sounds inflated rather than educated; slang in a serious setting punctures authority.

◆ LISTEN – EXERCISE 1: THE ARCHITECT'S CALL

An architect is updating a client who is converting an old store into a café. Halfway through, the client asks for plain English. Match each formal phrase (1–4) with the plain version the architect switches to (a–d).

1. the permit application is, in principle, approvable _____
 2. subject to a satisfactory structural review _____
 3. occupancy may commence upon issuance of the certificate _____
 4. any remedial works identified _____
- a) as long as the engineer says the building is safe · b) anything they ask us to fix · c) you'll get the permit · d) you can open once you've got the certificate

With a partner: what signal made the architect change register? Which dimension changed: field, tenor or mode?

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 2: LABEL THE REGISTER AND THE TONE

For each extract, name the formality level, the tone, and one marker that gives it away.

1. "Should you require any further assistance, please do not hesitate to contact the undersigned."
Level _____ Tone _____ Marker _____
2. "Right, so, long story short, the whole thing fell through. Pretty disappointing, honestly."
Level _____ Tone _____ Marker _____
3. "Ah yes, another flawless plan. What could possibly go wrong."
Level _____ Tone _____ Marker _____
4. "I wonder if it might be worth our looking at the figures once more before we decide?"
Level _____ Tone _____ Marker _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 3: SLIDE IT UP AND DOWN THE CLINE

Render this neutral message (a) as a frozen, official notice and (b) as an informal message to a friend. Move the whole cluster, not just the vocabulary.

Neutral: "Please submit your conference abstract by Friday; unfortunately, we can't consider late submissions."

(a) Frozen:

(b) Informal:

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 4: FIND AND FIX THE CLANG

Each message contains a marker from the wrong register. Underline it and rewrite so that the whole message agrees.

1. "We are writing to congratulate you on your retirement after thirty years of distinguished service, you absolute legend."

→ _____

2. "Hey Sam! Attached please find the revised deliverables for your perusal. See ya!"

→ _____

3. "The committee will utilize the feedback to commence a review."

→ _____

4. "Kindly be advised that the pizza's here, guys."

→ _____

5. "Dear Dr. Mensah, Hope you're good! Quick q about my grade: can you check it asap? Thx."

→ _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 5: TURN THE TONE DIAL

Keep the formality level. Change only the tone.

1. Make it **warm**: "Noted. This will be addressed in due course."

→ _____

2. Make it **cool**: "Thanks so much for sending this over so quickly; it's exactly what we needed!"

→ _____

3. Make it **deferential**: "Send me the final figures by noon."

→ _____

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: TOO STIFF, TOO LOOSE

Priya: I'm drafting the press release about the bakery closing. How does this sound? "The bakery is shutting its doors, which is a total bummer."

Marco: Warm, but "a total bummer" belongs in a text to a friend, not a press release.

Priya: Fair. "The Riverside Bakery will close permanently on March 28, following the retirement of its founder."

Marco: Much better. Now it's the right register, but it's a little cold for a place people love.

Priya: So I keep the formality and change the tone?

Marco: Exactly. Add the quotation from Rosa, and "after forty-two years of serving the neighborhood."

Priya: And the social post can be the loose one: "Last call for Rosa's cinnamon rolls! Riverside Bakery closes March 28 after 42 amazing years. Go say goodbye."

Marco: Perfect. Just don't put "Notice is hereby given" in the post.

Priya: Only if I'm being ironic.

Marco: Which, for a bakery's farewell, you're not.

Find the clang Marco spots. Which of Priya's lines are the same formality but a different tone?

◆ WITH A PARTNER – FIVE VOICES

Your group has one message card. The facts must be identical in all five versions; only the packaging changes. Write your voice, then justify it.

Voice	Reader	Field · tenor · mode	Two markers I used
1 Official notice			
2 Friendly email			
3 Press release			
4 Social post (280 characters)			
5 Tribute			

My voice (draft):

Clang hunt. When another group performs, write the voice number you hear, and note any stray marker.

Version I heard	A: ____ B: ____ C: ____ D: ____ E: ____
A clang I heard (quote it)	
One strength (quote it)	

◆ SELF-CHECK – CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

Which is a marker of high, formal register?

A) Phrasal verbs

B) Discourse fillers

C) Nominalization

2

Which sentence contains a register mismatch?

A) Please find attached the requested documents.

B) Here are those pics you wanted!

C) Please find attached the aforementioned pics.

3

Which reply is professional in register *and* warm in tone?

A) Noted. This will be addressed in due course.

B) Thank you so much for letting us know; we'll have this resolved by Friday and will update you the moment it's done.

C) Cheers, will sort it.

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ name the field, tenor and mode a situation calls for
- ◆ ☐ move one message along the formality cline, shifting the whole cluster of markers
- ◆ ☐ change the tone of a message without changing its formality

- ◆ ☐ find and fix a register clang, including over-formality
- ◆ ☐ write and deliver one message in five voices

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Recall a register misfire, yours or someone else's (real, invented or from a new identity card). Say what went wrong and which dimension slipped, then write a better version.

◆ READ AND SAY – NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

a binomial a trinomial irreversible fixedness restricted collocation a lexical bundle

a fixed simile a cliché a garble (an eggcorn) prefabricated overstuffing

by and large odds and ends part and parcel touch and go wear and tear

lock, stock and barrel a foregone conclusion a moot point a vested interest

drive a hard bargain bitterly disappointed few and far between

a **binomial** = a fixed pair of words in a fixed order (*salt and pepper*) · **restricted collocation** = a word that accepts essentially one partner · **an eggcorn** = a misheard version of a fixed phrase (*for all intensive purposes*)

◆ GRAMMAR BOX

Binomials and trinomials: the order is fixed.

by and large	generally	touch and go	uncertain, precarious
part and parcel	an inseparable part	null and void	legally invalid
give and take	mutual compromise	wear and tear	damage from normal use
odds and ends	small miscellaneous items	few and far between	rare
lock, stock and barrel	completely	hook, line and sinker	completely (deceived)

Restricted collocation: one partner only.

Natural	Logical, but not idiomatic
a foregone conclusion	a predetermined conclusion
a moot point	a discussable point
a vested interest	an invested interest
drive a hard bargain	make a hard bargain
a resounding success	a loud success
bitterly disappointed	harshly disappointed

Every chunk has a register. *to cut a long story short* (spoken) · *that said* (safe in writing) · *for what it's worth* (modest, conversational) · *at the end of the day* (worn to cliché: ration it). Fixed similes (*as easy as pie*, *as dry as a bone*) are informal by nature.

Exact or nothing. Not *a mute point* but *a moot point*; not *nip it in the butt* but *nip it in the bud*; not *peaked my interest* but *piqued*; not *on tender hooks* but *on tenterhooks*. And ration them: rarely more than one fixed expression per sentence.

◆ LISTEN – EXERCISE 1: THE INTERVIEW NEWS

Two friends talk about a job interview. Complete each chunk exactly as you hear it.

1. Don't keep me on _____.
2. To cut a long _____, I got it.
3. Signed, sealed and _____.
4. That's a _____ success!
5. I knew it was a _____ conclusion.
6. It was touch and _____ for a while.
7. They drive a hard _____.
8. Give and _____ on both sides.
9. By and _____, you played it beautifully.
10. For what it's _____, ...
11. Needless to _____, I'm relieved.
12. Some peace and _____ at last.

With a partner: twelve chunks in six turns. Does the conversation sound overstuffed? Why or why not?

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 2: COMPLETE THE CHUNK

Supply the missing word, in the correct, fixed order.

1. Long hours are part and _____ of the job.
2. By and _____, the reforms have worked.
3. Sooner or _____, the truth comes out.
4. He fell for the scam hook, line and _____.
5. The old contract is now null and _____.
6. I just want a little peace and _____.
7. The deposit covers damage, but not normal wear and _____.
8. Let's weigh the pros and _____ before we decide.
9. The drawer is full of odds and _____: batteries, keys, old receipts.
10. They sold the business lock, _____ and barrel.

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 3: CHOOSE THE STRONG COLLOCATE

Only one option is idiomatic. Circle it.

1. The result was a foregone / a predetermined conclusion.
2. She was bitterly / harshly disappointed.

3. He drives / makes a hard bargain.
4. Whether he knew is now a moot / a mute point.
5. The launch was a resounding / a loud success.
6. Real bargains are few and far between / few and rare.
7. As a shareholder, she has a vested / an invested interest in the outcome.
8. Since childhood he'd had a burning / a hot ambition to fly.

◆ WRITE — EXERCISE 4: FIX THE GARBLE

Each sentence contains a misheard or misordered fixed expression. Correct it.

1. For all intensive purposes, the project is finished. _____
2. It's a doggy-dog world out there. _____
3. We need to nip this problem in the butt. _____
4. That documentary really peaked my interest. _____
5. After the drought, the fields were dry as a stone. _____
6. We waited on tender hooks for the decision. _____
7. You should of told me earlier. _____
8. They made him the escape goat for the whole delay. _____

◆ WRITE — EXERCISE 5: A SMALL NATURALNESS AUDIT

This paragraph from a project report was written by a very proficient user. It contains six naturalness problems. Underline each, label it (ORDER · PARTNER · GARBLE · REGISTER · STUFFING) and fix it.

Large and by, the pilot was a success. We had our ups and downs, of course: the first week was touch and go, and the new software was as easy as pie to break, although the IT team nipped most bugs in the butt. The supplier, who has an invested interest in the contract, made a hard bargain on price. That said, when all is said and done, at the end of the day, the results speak for themselves, and a full rollout now looks like a foregone conclusion.

Problem	Label	Fix

Seams test. Read your repaired text aloud to the other pair. Can they hear a chunk that was bolted on? If so, cut or replace it.

Odds and Ends (card game). Turn over two cards. If they make a binomial, say it in the right order and use it in a natural sentence within five seconds to keep the pair. Binomials I used well in the game:

◆ SELF-CHECK – CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

Which is the correct, fixed order?

A) peace and quiet

B) quiet and peace

C) peace or quiet

2

Which word completes the restricted collocation "a _____ conclusion" (an outcome certain in advance)?

A) predetermined

B) foregone

C) inevitable

3

Which sentence contains a garbled fixed expression?

A) It was touch and go for a while.

B) Once the contract expired, the old agreement was null and void.

C) Her question really peaked my interest.

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ use common binomials and trinomials in their fixed order, as one unit

- ◆ ☐ choose the one idiomatic partner in a restricted collocation
- ◆ ☐ place lexical bundles and fixed similes in the register where they belong
- ◆ ☐ spot and correct garbled fixed expressions
- ◆ ☐ audit a text for naturalness and cut chunks that sound bolted on

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Start a chunk archive. Copy one fixed expression you met this week exactly as you found it, say where it belongs (and where it would clang), and use it in a sentence of your own.

Reading Between the Lines: Pragmatics

Three lessons about the distance between what is said and what is meant. Learn to hear the verdict folded inside a polite remark and to deliver one yourself, deniably; to enjoy, analyze and craft irony, understatement and the well-placed pun; and to see the hidden metaphors that organize everyday English, then build a passage on one image of your own.

Lessons 2.1-2.3

Classes C4-C6

Level C2

Name: _____

HOW THIS MODULE WORKS

Each heading tells you the kind of task: **Read, Listen, Write, Say** or **Pair work**. Almost every task here has more than one good answer. What matters is precision (the exact word that carries the meaning), appropriacy (the right strength for the reader and the room) and effect (would a proficient listener infer what you intended?). When a task draws on your own experience, you decide what to share: your real life, a new identity card, or something you invent. All three are equally good. The criticism and difficult messages in this module are written on cards; you encode the card's message, not your own opinion of anyone. In the humor lesson you will analyze and write, but you never have to perform a joke. You can always say "Pass."

◆ READ AND SAY — NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

pragmatics speaker meaning implicature to infer a maxim to flout a maxim
 deniable to damn with faint praise a presupposition a trigger a loaded question
 to refuse the premise face-threatening off the record strategic vagueness slant
 a distancing marker juxtaposition

Indirect moves (each one lets the listener draw the conclusion):

I couldn't help noticing... You might want to... It's not really my place, but...
 That's one way of doing it. I'm sure you had your reasons. It's certainly... bold.
 Have you had a chance to...? Let's just say it wasn't a triumph. Let's circle back on that.
 With the greatest respect...

implicature = what a speaker means beyond the literal words, inferred from context · **presupposition** = what a sentence takes for granted as already true · **to flout** = to break a rule openly, so that everyone notices and draws a conclusion

◆ GRAMMAR BOX — THE MACHINERY OF THE UNSAID

Four expectations we have of a cooperative speaker, and what we infer when one is visibly broken:

Quantity: say enough	"Is she good at her job?" "She's very punctual." → She has no better quality worth mentioning.
Quality: say what's true	In a downpour: "Well, that was a lovely day out." → It was a disaster (irony).
Relation: be relevant	"What did you think of my presentation?" "Shall we get coffee?" → I'd rather not say.
Manner: be clear	"Did they sing?" "They produced a series of sounds corresponding to the score." → It was barely singing.

Presupposition triggers. A presupposition survives negation: "Your team is **still** behind" and "Your team isn't **still** behind" both assume it was behind.

stop · start · keep

Have you stopped cutting corners? → you were cutting corners

again · still · yet	Are you late again? → you've been late before
even · only	Even Tom passed. → Tom was the least likely to pass
the · possessives	the mistake in your figures → there is a mistake
realize · regret · admit	When did you realize the plan was flawed? → it was flawed
manage to	Did you manage to finish? → finishing was difficult

Refusing the premise. Never answer a loaded question with yes or no. Name the assumption, reject it, reframe: *That question assumes X, which isn't the case. What I can tell you is...*

Slant in writing comes from four levers: **diction** (*insisted* rather than *said*), **omission** (the question not asked), **juxtaposition** (two facts placed side by side) and **distancing markers** (*reportedly, allegedly, apparently, so-called*, scare quotes).

◆ LISTEN – EXERCISE 1: THE REFERENCE CALL

Dana, a hiring manager, phones Mr. Okafor for a reference for Leo, who has applied to lead a team. Complete Mr. Okafor's words.

1. "Leo was always very _____. Never missed a day."
2. "He certainly had a lot of _____ for new projects."
3. "And his presentations were always very _____."
4. "He was extremely popular at team _____."
5. "We've _____ the department since then, so it's hard to say."
6. "I think it's fair to say he always got there _____."

With a partner: what does each line imply, and which expectation does it flout? Then find the one question in which Dana herself presupposes something.

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 2: STATE THE IMPLICATURE

Write what each speaker or writer really means, and name the mechanism (quantity, quality, relation, manner, or an indirect move).

1. (Email about a report) "Thanks for sending this. I can see you've used a lot of different fonts."
→ _____
2. "How is Maria handling the new clients?" "She always answers the phone very politely."
→ _____

3. (Café review) "The chairs are comfortable and the Wi-Fi is fast. I'll bring my own coffee next time."

→ _____

4. "Can we talk about the budget?" "Did anyone catch the game last night?"

→ _____

5. (After a colleague's three-hour workshop) "Well, it was certainly thorough."

→ _____

6. (Meeting minutes) "The chair thanked everyone for a lively exchange of views."

→ _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 3: WHAT IS TAKEN FOR GRANTED?

Underline the trigger and write what the sentence presupposes.

1. Have you fixed the error in the invoice yet? → _____

2. Even the new intern spotted the problem. → _____

3. Are you working from home again? → _____

4. Do you regret signing the contract? → _____

5. She only finished second. → _____

6. Did you manage to speak to the landlord? → _____

Now refuse the premise before you answer.

7. "Why is your department still so disorganized?"

→ _____

8. "When did the team stop following the safety checklist?"

→ _____

◆ READ – EXERCISE 4: THE VERDICT BETWEEN THE LINES

Nothing in this news item is false. Circle five words or phrases that slant it, and label each lever (diction, omission, juxtaposition, distancing).

The company's much-anticipated app, which reportedly crashed twice during the launch event, was described by its chief executive as "a game-changer." She declined to take questions. A modest crowd of some forty people attended; the company's press release put the figure at "well over two hundred."

The verdict the writer never states: _____

Rewrite the item in one or two neutral sentences, keeping every fact:

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 5: IMPLY IT, DON'T STATE IT

Rewrite each blunt message so that it is understood but could be denied. No sentence may state the message.

1. (To a colleague) "Your slides have far too much text."

→ _____

2. (Replying to a proposal) "This plan will not work."

→ _____

3. (To a friend who wants to borrow your car again) "No."

→ _____

4. (In a hotel review) "The room was dirty."

→ _____

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: DECODING THE DIRECTOR

Sam: Helen finally replied about my proposal. "It's clear a great deal of work went into it. It's certainly comprehensive."

Priya: Comprehensive. Hmm.

Sam: What's wrong with comprehensive?

Priya: Nothing, on its own. But it's the only adjective in the email. What else does she say?

Sam: "We've decided to go in a slightly different direction for now."

Priya: "For now" is doing a lot of work there. I'd read that as a polite no.

Sam: Then: "Has the budget section been checked by finance yet?"

Priya: That "yet" assumes it should have been. She has doubts about your numbers.

Sam: So "comprehensive" actually means...

Priya: Too long, probably. Deniably, of course. Ask her and she'll say it was a compliment.

Sam: And she signs off, "Let's touch base next quarter."

Priya: Which is three months away. I'd take the hint: fix the budget, cut it to two pages, and send it back before she asks.

Underline every phrase that implies more than it says. What three messages should Sam take from Helen's email? Which one would be hardest for Helen to deny?

◆ PAIR WORK – IMPLICATURE LAB

Round 1: Decode. Your group gets one text: an email, a reference, a review or a set of minutes. For every loaded phrase, complete the table.

Said (quote it)	Meant	Mechanism
-----------------	-------	-----------

The real message, in one line: _____

Round 2: Encode. Draw a card. Write a 4–6 line email or exchange that conveys its message entirely by implication.

☐ one flouted expectation · ☐ one presupposition trigger · ☐ one indirect move from the bank · ☐ no sentence states the message · ☐ every line could be defended literally

Round 3: Peer test. Swap texts. Write the message you inferred, and how strong it is.

The real message (one line)	
Strength: mild · clear · severe	
Result: pass · too buried · too bald	
One strength (quote it)	
One suggestion (quote it)	

◆ SAY — SELF-CHECK: CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

"Did you enjoy the concert?" "The program notes were beautifully printed." What is the implicature, and how is it produced?

A) The speaker only cared about the printing.

B) It presupposes that the concert was canceled.

C) The concert was disappointing, implied by praising only a trivial detail.

2

Which question takes a damaging premise for granted?

A) "What did the committee decide about the data?"

B) "When will you admit the data was falsified?"

C) "Do you think the data might be reviewed?"

3

In a meeting, a director asks you: "Why is your team still behind schedule?" Your team is, in fact, on track for the revised date. What is the best first move?

A) "We're not that far behind, honestly."

B) "That question assumes we're behind schedule. In fact, we're on track for the revised date. Let me show you."

C) "Sorry about that. We'll catch up soon."

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ say what a speaker means, not only what the words say, and name the expectation they flouted
- ◆ ☐ explain why an implied meaning is deniable, and why that makes it useful
- ◆ ☐ spot presupposition triggers (*still, again, even, only, the, realize, manage to*) and refuse a loaded premise
- ◆ ☐ read a text for the verdict it never states (diction, omission, juxtaposition, distancing)
- ◆ ☐ convey a difficult message by implication, at the strength I intend

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Recall a conversation (real, invented, or from a new identity card) in which someone meant more, or less, than they said. What was said, and what was meant?

◆ READ AND SAY — NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

verbal irony sarcasm deadpan understatement litotes hyperbole

situational irony dramatic irony a pun a pivot word a homophone a malapropism

a spoonerism a double entendre the setup incongruity the punchline

self-deprecation to land to fall flat

Ironic set phrases (praise that means the opposite):

Oh, fantastic. Just what I needed. Well, that went well. Couldn't be better.

Lovely weather for it. Nice one.

Understatement (the listener supplies the missing emotion):

a bit of a problem not exactly ideal I've had better days not our finest hour

slightly overdue no small feat not bad at all a few reservations

◆ GRAMMAR BOX — HOW THE GAP IS MADE

Verbal irony	saying the opposite, trusting the listener to hear it; can be gentle or self-directed	(stuck in traffic) "Well, this is going brilliantly."
Sarcasm	irony with a target and an edge; meant to sting	(to someone parked across two spaces) "Oh, nice parking."
Understatement	saying far less than the situation deserves	(the projector caught fire) "It wasn't our finest hour."
Hyperbole	obvious exaggeration, for emphasis or comedy	"I've been on hold for a geological age."
Situational irony	an outcome contrary to expectation	The fire station burns down.
Dramatic irony	the audience knows what the character doesn't	We know the letter is in her pocket; she searches the house.

How we hear irony: heavy **stress** ("Well, *THIS* is going brilliantly"), an exaggerated or completely flat **tone**, and above all a **clash** between the words and the situation. In writing, only the clash survives, so irony in

print must be unmistakable or not attempted.

Pun	one word, two active meanings, or two words that sound alike	I used to be a banker, but I lost interest .
Malapropism	a wrong word that sounds like the right one	a real escape goat (scapegoat)
Spoonerism	the first sounds of two words swapped	a well-boiled icicle (a well-oiled bicycle)

The architecture of a joke: **setup** (an expectation) → **incongruity** (something that doesn't fit) → **punchline** (a second frame snaps into place, and it comes last). **Who pays?** Safe targets are situations, objects, systems and yourself. Humor about people's nationality, religion, accent, body or disability is never on the menu.

◆ LISTEN – EXERCISE 1: SINCERE, IRONIC OR UNDERSTATED?

Your teacher reads eight lines, each with its situation. Circle **S** (sincere), **I** (ironic or sarcastic) or **U** (understated), and note the signal that told you.

1	S · I · U	signal: _____	5	S · I · U	signal: _____
2	S · I · U	signal: _____	6	S · I · U	signal: _____
3	S · I · U	signal: _____	7	S · I · U	signal: _____
4	S · I · U	signal: _____	8	S · I · U	signal: _____

With a partner: items 1 and 2 use the same words, and so do items 3 and 4. What changed the meaning?

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 2: WHAT'S REALLY MEANT?

Write what the speaker means, and name the device (irony, sarcasm, understatement, litotes or hyperbole).

1. (A software update has just deleted a week of data.) "Well, that could have gone better."

→ _____

2. "I've only been on hold for a lifetime."

→ _____

3. "The new printer is not exactly a triumph of engineering."

→ _____

4. (A friend returns your car with an empty tank.) "Thanks for leaving me so much gas."

→ _____

5. "He's not the most punctual person I've ever worked with."

→ _____

6. (Handed a 500-page manual on Friday afternoon.) "A little light reading for the weekend."

→ _____

◆ WRITE — EXERCISE 3: THE HEADLINE DESK

For each headline, write the pivot word and its two meanings.

1. OPTICIANS SEE EYE TO EYE ON NEW HOURS

→ _____

2. CLOCKMAKER'S BUSINESS WINDS DOWN AFTER 40 YEARS

→ _____

3. BEEKEEPERS CREATE A BUZZ AT FARMERS MARKET

→ _____

4. NEW BRIDGE PROJECT SPANS TWO DECADES

→ _____

5. GARDENERS DIG IN OVER NEW PARK RULES

→ _____

6. Now write your own pun headline (7 words or fewer) for this story: *A yoga studio opens a second location.*

→ _____

◆ WRITE — EXERCISE 4: NAME IT AND FIX IT

Name the device (malapropism, spoonerism, situational irony or dramatic irony). For a malapropism or spoonerism, write what was intended.

1. "She was the escape goat for the whole failed project." _____

2. "For all intensive purposes, the job is finished." _____

3. "It's a doggy-dog world out there." _____

4. (A nervous student at the dean's door) "Excuse me, is the bean dizzy?" _____

5. The new time-management app launched three months late. _____

6. We know the missing ring is in the cake; the guests keep complimenting the cake.

◆ WRITE — EXERCISE 5: BLUNT INTO DRY

Rewrite each blunt statement with understatement or gentle irony. The target must be the situation or yourself.

1. "This meeting is a complete waste of time."

→ _____

2. "The traffic this morning was a disaster."

→ _____

3. "My presentation went terribly."

→ _____

4. "The instructions for this bookshelf are impossible to follow."

→ _____

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: THE MORNING AFTER THE PRESENTATION

Maya: How did the client presentation go? I heard the projector caught fire.

Dev: Oh, it went swimmingly.

Maya: And the client? Are they still with us?

Dev: Let's just say they had a few reservations.

Maya: So, not our finest hour.

Dev: No. Though on the bright side, I've now seen a projector achieve self-awareness, so, small mercies.

Maya: Wonderful. I'll draft the apology.

Dev: You're a saint. Truly. And next time, I'm presenting with a flip chart. At least paper has the decency to burn quietly.

Label each of Dev's and Maya's lines: irony, understatement, hyperbole or sincere. Who is the target of the humor? Why does that make it safe?

◆ PAIR WORK – WIT WORKSHOP

Round 1: Headline Desk. Write a pun headline (7 words or fewer) for each of your two story cards, and name the pivot word.

Story 1: _____ pivot: _____

Story 2: _____ pivot: _____

Round 2: Comic piece. A mock review of a mundane object, or a wry anecdote about a small disaster. 80–120 words. Name your audience first.

☐ irony or sarcasm aimed at an object or situation · ☐ understatement or hyperbole · ☐ one piece of wordplay · ☐ the punchline comes last · ☐ audience: _____

Round 3: Gap and Target review. Swap with another pair.

The gap: where do said and meant come apart? (quote)	
The signals: could a reader take any line literally?	
The target: who pays for the joke?	
The cut: one word that delays the punchline	
One strength · one suggestion	

Reading your piece aloud is optional. You may read it, ask someone else to read it, simply show it, or pass.

◆ SAY — SELF-CHECK: CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

After her flight is canceled, a stranded traveler sighs, "Well, this is going brilliantly." What is she doing?

A) Using irony: she means it's going terribly.

B) Using hyperbole to exaggerate her delight.

C) Making a pun on "brilliantly."

2

"I used to be a banker, but I lost interest." Why is this a pun?

A) The first sounds of two words have been swapped.

B) A wrong word has been used by accident.

C) "Interest" carries two meanings at once: money a bank pays, and enthusiasm.

3

You are giving a short welcome speech to new colleagues you barely know. Which kind of humor is the safest choice?

A) A sarcastic remark about the manager's choice of tie

B) A gently self-deprecating line about your own hopeless sense of direction on your first day

C) A double entendre about the office party

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ tell irony from sarcasm, and hear the signals (stress, tone, context clash)
- ◆ ☐ use understatement for dry humor and tact, and keep hyperbole for when it counts
- ◆ ☐ explain exactly how a pun, a malapropism or a spoonerism works
- ◆ ☐ decode and write a pun headline
- ◆ ☐ judge who pays for a joke, and choose humor that suits the room

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Recall a moment when humor in English landed or fell flat (yours, someone else's, or invented). Which device was at work, and what signal was present or missing?

◆ READ AND SAY — NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

figurative / literal

a metaphor

a simile

metonymy

synecdoche

personification

a conceptual metaphor

a source domain

a target domain

a dead metaphor

a cliché

a live metaphor

a sustained (extended) metaphor

a controlling metaphor

a mixed metaphor

imagery

to refresh

to re-coin

source domain = the concrete world an image is borrowed from (war, money, food, a journey) · **target domain** = the abstract idea it describes (argument, time, ideas, life)

◆ GRAMMAR BOX — THE FIGURES AND THE MAPS

Metaphor	X is Y: fuses two things; can be sustained	Her argument was a fortress.
Simile	X is like Y / as ... as: invites comparison	Fear rose in him like cold water in a cellar.
Metonymy	naming by association	The front desk called. · Hollywood loved it.
Synecdoche	naming by part (or whole)	All hands on deck. · nice wheels
Personification	human qualities for non-human things	The old house groaned in the wind.

Conceptual metaphors: whole families of everyday expressions share one map.

ARGUMENT IS WAR	defend a claim · attack a position · shoot down an idea · win the point · indefensible
TIME IS MONEY	spend · save · waste · budget your day · that cost me a week · borrowed time
IDEAS ARE FOOD	food for thought · half-baked · hard to swallow · digest · chew it over · raw data
LIFE IS A JOURNEY	at a crossroads · a dead-end job · moving on · we've come a long way
UP IS GOOD	spirits rose · feeling down · things are looking up · morale sank
UNDERSTANDING IS SEEING	I see · a clear argument · a murky explanation · shed light on it

Dead metaphors are invisible (*the leg of the table*); **clichés** are visible and tired (*think outside the box*): refresh or re-coin them; **live** metaphors still make the reader see (*hope is the thing with feathers*). A

sustained metaphor draws every image from one source domain. A **mixed metaphor** puts two incompatible pictures in one frame: *We'll burn that bridge when we come to it.*

◆ LISTEN – EXERCISE 1: THE LIBRARY AT CLOSING TIME

Your teacher reads a short descriptive passage. Complete the images.

The overhead lights (1) _____ off row by row, like heavy (2) _____. The building (3) _____, a long, slow breath of warm paper and dust. Somewhere in its (4) _____, the heating rumbles and settles. The returns cart is (5) _____ its final meal of books. By nine the great creature is (6) _____ around its silence.

What is the controlling metaphor? Find one simile, and one image of personification that fits the frame.

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 2: NAME THE FIGURE AND ITS EFFECT

Name the figure, then say in a phrase what it achieves.

1. "The front desk says our room isn't ready."

→ _____

2. "His inbox was a swamp he waded through every morning."

→ _____

3. "The old elevator complained all the way to the ninth floor."

→ _____

4. "The news spread through the office like a spilled drink across a table."

→ _____

5. "We need a few more hands for the Saturday shift."

→ _____

6. "Hollywood has discovered our small town."

→ _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 3: WHICH FAMILY?

Write W (ARGUMENT IS WAR), T (TIME IS MONEY), F (IDEAS ARE FOOD) or J (LIFE IS A JOURNEY).

a. Her criticisms were right on target. _____ b. Is it worth your while? _____ c. That idea needs time to simmer. _____

d. She's really going places. _____ e. He retreated from his original position. _____ f. I've invested a lot of time in this course. _____

- g. I can't stomach that claim. _____ h. We've hit a bump in the road. _____ i. I've never won an argument with her. _____
- j. We're running out of time. _____ k. The report is thin; it needs more meat. _____ l. He feels he has lost his way. _____

Extend the map: coin one new expression for ARGUMENT IS WAR and one for IDEAS ARE FOOD that a proficient reader would accept.

W: _____

F: _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 4: FIX THE MIX, REFRESH THE CLICHÉ

Say what is wrong (mixed images, clichés, or both), then rewrite with one coherent, fresh image or plain words.

1. "We'll have to take the bull by the horns and dive in at the deep end."
→ _____
2. "The new manager is a breath of fresh air who will shake the tree and plant new seeds."
→ _____
3. "At the end of the day, we need to think outside the box."
→ _____
4. "This project has been a roller coaster, but we're on the home stretch now and it's plain sailing."
→ _____
5. "Our competitors have raised the bar, so we need to move the goalposts."
→ _____

◆ READ – EXERCISE 5: ANALYZE THE IMAGERY

Before sunrise the market is a stage waiting for its cast. Stallholders arrive like stagehands, dragging scenery of crates and awnings into place. At six the lights come up: the first rays catch the oranges, and the fruit takes a bow. The fishmonger clears his throat and delivers his opening lines to an audience of early shoppers. By eight the whole company is in full voice, every stall a scene, every bargain a small drama. Then, at noon, the market runs out of gas, and the curtain falls on another sold-out performance.

- a. The controlling metaphor and its source domain: _____
- b. Underline six images drawn from that domain. Which one is a simile? _____
- c. One image breaks the frame. Which, and what would you replace it with? _____
- d. Which image do you find freshest, and why? _____

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: THE WRITING GROUP

Ana: Here's my opening: "At rush hour the city is an ocean. Commuters surge through the station in waves, and the escalators pull them under."

Joon: I like it. I can see the tide. Is the whole paragraph the sea?

Ana: Mostly. Then: "The ticket barriers are a bottleneck, and everyone is running on fumes."

Joon: That's where I fell out of the water. A bottle and a car engine, in the middle of an ocean?

Ana: Hm. Fair. So the barriers could be... rocks? "The barriers are a reef the crowd breaks against."

Joon: Much better. And "running on fumes" is a bit of a cliché anyway.

Ana: "Everyone is swimming against their own exhaustion"?

Joon: Now you're sustaining it. One sea, start to finish. I'd just stop before you get to the sharks.

Which two images broke Ana's frame? What was the controlling metaphor? What does Joon mean by "stop before you get to the sharks"?

◆ PAIR WORK – FIGURATIVE LANGUAGE STUDIO

Round 1: Analyze. Your group's passage. Controlling metaphor: _____ The image that breaks the frame: _____ The cliché: _____

Round 2: Write. Subject: _____ Source domain: _____

My controlling metaphor, in one line: _____

☐ 120–150 words · ☐ one source domain, at least four sentences · ☐ two or three supporting images (simile, personification, metonymy) that fit it · ☐ no clichés left · ☐ nothing pushed one image too far

Round 3: Name the frame. Read your partner's passage silently and write before you speak.

The controlling metaphor and source domain	
The strongest image (quote it)	
Any image that breaks the frame	
One cliché to refresh	

◆ SAY – SELF-CHECK: CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

"All hands on deck" is an example of which figure?

A) Synecdoche

B) Personification

C) Simile

2

Which sentence is a mixed metaphor?

A) "The firm was adrift, taking on water, with no one at the helm."

B) "We'll burn that bridge when we come to it."

C) "Grief settled on her like snow, silent and slowly deepening."

3

A colleague writes: "We need to nip this problem in the bud before it snowballs." Which revision keeps one coherent image?

A) "We need to nip this problem in the bud before it spreads through the whole garden."

B) "We need to nip this problem in the bud before the bud snowballs."

C) "We need to nip this snowball in the bud."

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ name a metaphor, simile, metonymy, synecdoche or personification, and say what it achieves
- ◆ ☐ sort everyday expressions into their conceptual metaphor, and coin a new one on the same map
- ◆ ☐ tell dead, clichéd and live metaphors apart, and refresh a cliché
- ◆ ☐ analyze the imagery of a descriptive passage and spot the image that breaks the frame
- ◆ ☐ write a short passage built on one sustained metaphor

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Note two expressions you heard or read this week that belong to a conceptual metaphor (a headline, a

colleague's phrase, an advertisement). Name the map each one belongs to.

Discourse Mastery: Structure & Cohesion

Three lessons that move from the sentence to the whole text. Steer a stretch of discourse with the small words that organize it and color it with attitude, and learn to hear the same words working on you.

Engineer long texts that a reader follows without effort. Then give back other people's meaning, as a faithful summary, a genuine paraphrase and a fair synthesis, without distorting a source or borrowing its words.

Lessons 3.1-3.3

Classes C7-C9

Level C2

Name: _____

HOW THIS MODULE WORKS

Each exercise heading tells you what to do: **Read, Listen, Write, Say** or **Pair work**. Most tasks here have several good answers. Judge yours by three questions: Is it faithful to the facts? Does it fit its reader and its register? Does it have the effect you intended?

Every stance you write in class is **assigned**: writing the skeptical version of a report is practice in a register, not a statement of belief. When a task draws on your own life or writing, you decide what to share. Use your real experience, **or** a new identity card, **or** something you invent. All three are equally good, and you can always say "Pass."

◆ READ AND SAY — NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

a discourse marker

stance

a stance adverbial

an interactional
marker

register

slant

a concession

to signpost

to editorialize

appropriacy

admittedly

arguably

presumably

ostensibly

reportedly

tellingly

remarkably

mercifully

technically

broadly speaking

if anything

that said

be that as it may

mind you

the thing is

let's face it

stance = the attitude a speaker or writer takes toward what they say: certainty, evaluation, viewpoint · **slant** = an attitude built into a text that presents itself as neutral · **to editorialize** = to insert your own opinion into what should be a report

◆ GRAMMAR BOX

Organizing markers change nothing in the facts; they tell the reader where we are. Their register is their most visible feature.

Function	Spoken / casual	Written / formal
Open	Right, so... · Now, the thing is...	To begin with · Let us first consider
Add	On top of that · Plus...	Furthermore · What is more
Concede	That said · Mind you · To be fair	Nevertheless · Admittedly · Be that as it may
Shift	Anyway · By the way · Speaking of which	Turning to... · As for... · With regard to...
Close	Long story short · So there you have it	In short · All in all · In conclusion

Stance adverbials comment on the whole clause. One word can turn a report into an opinion.

Epistemic (how sure)	admittedly · arguably · presumably · apparently · seemingly · undoubtedly · conceivably · ostensibly
Attitude (how I feel)	frankly · honestly · regrettably · remarkably · curiously · ironically · mercifully · understandably · tellingly

Viewpoint (from where)	personally · technically · theoretically · broadly speaking · to my knowledge · reportedly
Focus (what, exactly)	notably · specifically · at least · if anything · for that matter

Front	<i>Frankly, the scheme was doomed.</i> (the comma marks a comment on the whole clause)
Medial	<i>The result, remarkably, held.</i> (an aside, said on a lower pitch)
Final	<i>He said nothing, tellingly.</i> (a quiet verdict)
Not stance	<i>She spoke frankly.</i> (manner: in a frank way)

Use them sparingly. Weak: *Frankly, honestly, to be fair, the plan arguably failed.* Stronger: *The plan, arguably, failed.* One well-placed adverbial colors a sentence; four cancel one another out.

◆ LISTEN – EXERCISE 1: THE MUSEUM COMMENTARY

Your teacher reads a short spoken commentary from a culture podcast. Write the missing marker, then label it **O** (organizing), **S** (stance) or **I** (interactional).

(1) _____ [], the Harbor Street Museum has finally reopened, and I went on Saturday. (2) _____ [], I went in expecting to be disappointed. (3) _____ [], the building looks wonderful. (4) _____ [], the big change is the layout. (5) _____ [], that makes the collection far more approachable for younger visitors. (6) _____ [], it also means a Roman oil lamp now sits beside a 1970s toaster, which, (7) _____ [], made me laugh out loud. (8) _____ [], the busiest room on Saturday was the old map room they left untouched.

What is the speaker's attitude to the museum? Which three words revealed it most clearly?

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 2: CHOOSE THE STANCE

Choose the adverbial that gives the attitude in brackets.

- (concede a point against yourself) _____, my own figures were incomplete. [frankly / admittedly / undoubtedly]
- (mark a perverse twist) _____, the diet plan made her hungrier. [understandably / ironically / broadly speaking]
- (distance yourself from an unverified claim) _____, the festival has been canceled. [reportedly / personally / mercifully]
- (spotlight one striking case) One judge, _____, refused to sign. [notably / theoretically / apparently]

5. (a reasonable inference, not knowledge) _____, the caterers will need the final numbers by Friday.
[presumably / undoubtedly / frankly]
6. (the stated reason, with a hint of a hidden one) The meeting was, _____, about scheduling.
[ostensibly / notably / mercifully]
7. (true by a strict definition only) _____, the building is still a library, although it now lends more tools than books. [Technically / Honestly / Remarkably]
8. (correct toward the opposite of what was expected) The new layout hasn't slowed us down; _____, it has made us faster. [if anything / at least / for that matter]

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 3: FUNCTION AND REGISTER

For each marker, write its function (organizing, stance or interactional) and its natural register (spoken / casual, written / formal, or both).

1. furthermore	_____
2. anyway	_____
3. arguably	_____
4. the thing is	_____
5. to sum up	_____
6. mind you	_____
7. be that as it may	_____
8. long story short	_____
9. tellingly	_____
10. let's face it	_____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 4: SAME FACTS, DIFFERENT TEMPERATURE

The paragraph below is complete but flat. Rewrite it twice as a short written review: first in a clearly **approving** stance, then in a clearly **skeptical** one. Keep every fact; add organizing and stance markers only (three to five per version).

"The city's new central library opened in May. It cost \$14 million. Visitor numbers have tripled. The café closes at 4 p.m. The reading room is often too noisy to work in. The architect has won a national award."

Approving

Skeptical

Which marker did the most work in each version? _____

◆ READ – EXERCISE 5: READ THE SLANT, THEN STRIP IT

"The so-called upgrade to the office booking system was, supposedly, designed to save staff time. Needless to say, it did nothing of the kind. To be fair, the new calendar view is an improvement, though, tellingly, nobody on the project team seems to use it."

1. Underline every stance or discourse marker. Beside each, write what it quietly signals.
2. The Strip test: write the bare facts only, with every marker removed.

3. How much of the "argument" survived? _____
4. Rewrite the passage in a judiciously balanced stance, keeping the facts.

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: AFTER THE EXHIBITION

Maya: So, honestly, what did you make of the exhibition?

Theo: Well... mixed, to be honest. The early rooms were, arguably, the strongest, technically dazzling. But the thing is, by the last gallery it felt, I mean, a bit repetitive. Mind you, that might just be me.

Maya: No, I know exactly what you mean. And let's face it, the ticket price was, frankly, absurd.

Theo: Absurd. Though, to be fair, it is for a good cause.

Maya: True. And, curiously, the gift shop was the busiest room in the building.

Theo: Tellingly.

Circle the **stance** adverbials and underline the **interactional** markers. What is Theo's final "Tellingly" saying without saying it? Read the dialogue with a partner, pausing after each fronted marker.

◆ PAIR WORK — STANCE WORKSHOP

Round 1. Your group has one neutral report. Rewrite it three times. Keep every fact; add nothing; use three to five markers per version, never three in one sentence, and at least one medial or final adverbial.

Skeptical

Approving

Judiciously balanced

Round 2: Peer review. Read another group's versions with the headings folded under.

Version 1 · stance I read · two words that told me	
Version 2 · stance I read · two words that told me	
Version 3 · stance I read · two words that told me	
Strip test on version ____: facts identical?	yes / no: _____
One strength (quote it)	

One suggestion (quote it)

Round 3: Stance Detective. Speak for 90 seconds on your topic card in your secret attitude. Your partner names the attitude and quotes two markers. Attitude my partner heard: _____

◆ SAY — SELF-CHECK: CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

"Ostensibly, the visit was a courtesy call." What does *ostensibly* add?

- A) It confirms the reason beyond any doubt.
- B) It expresses the speaker's relief about the visit.
- C) It signals the stated reason, hinting that the true reason is otherwise.

2

Which marker belongs to spoken, casual register and would jar in a formal essay?

- A) furthermore
- B) anyway
- C) nevertheless

3

Which sentence keeps a consistent register for a formal written report?

- A) The trial, admittedly, was small; anyway, the results were encouraging.
- B) The trial was, admittedly, small; nevertheless, the results were encouraging.
- C) The trial was small, you know, but, mind you, the results were encouraging.

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ choose organizing markers that fit both the function and the register
- ◆ ☐ plant a precise attitude with one stance adverbial, and tell near-neighbors apart (*admittedly* / *arguably* · *apparently* / *ostensibly*)
- ◆ ☐ punctuate and position a stance adverbial for the effect I want
- ◆ ☐ use interactional markers in speech and keep them out of formal writing

- ◆ ☐ read and strip the slant in someone else's text

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Which stance adverbial do you most want to activate? Write one real or invented sentence that uses it well.

◆ READ AND SAY — NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

cohesion

coherence

theme

rheme

information flow

a lexical chain

a superordinate

elegant variation

meta-discourse

a topic sentence

a through-line

an ordering principle

This raises a further question:

So far, then, ...

Against this backdrop, ...

A very different picture emerges when...

None of this, however, addresses...

Having established that..., we can now turn to...

as we shall see

All of which brings us to...

cohesion = the visible links between sentences: reference, connectives, related words · **coherence** = whether the text makes sense as one connected line of thought · **theme / rheme** = the starting point of a clause (usually given) / the rest of it, which carries the news · **elegant variation** = renaming the same thing so often that the reader loses track

◆ GRAMMAR BOX

Two virtues. Ask first: is the **wiring** missing, or the **thought**?

Cohesive, not coherent	<i>The committee approved the budget. However, the budget is a document. Moreover, paper comes from trees. (links everywhere; no thought)</i>
Coherent, not cohesive	<i>The scheme failed. Nobody had been consulted. (sound logic; bare joins) → The scheme failed because nobody had been consulted.</i>

Given before new. Start each sentence on familiar ground; end on the news, then hand the news forward.

Linear ("staircase")	The lecture introduced a new theory . This theory challenges the standard model . The standard model had gone unquestioned for decades.
Constant theme	The novel divided critics. It sold well but baffled some. Its admirers hailed it as a landmark.
Tools to move news to the end	a summary noun (<i>This decline...</i>) · the passive · <i>there is</i> · an <i>it</i> -cleft (<i>It is this single thread, trust, that...</i>)

Lexical chains. Repetition · synonym · superordinate · general word · collocation: *the drought* → *the dry spell* → *the water shortage* → *the crisis*. Repeat the anchor term with confidence. Weak: *the novel... the*

book... the work... the volume... the tome.

Macro-structure. Topic sentence → development → link. Ordering principles: chronological · general → specific · specific → general · problem → solution · claim → evidence · compare / contrast. Signpost the turns, not every step. **The skeleton test:** reduce each paragraph to one sentence and read the list. Does it make an argument?

◆ LISTEN – EXERCISE 1: THE LECTURE OPENING

Your teacher reads the opening of a history lecture. Complete the signposts, then name the move each one makes (preview, sequence, internal summary, transition).

Today's lecture (1) _____ the history of the city park is, at heart, a history of public health. (2) _____ the crowded industrial city of the 1840s, (3) _____ the reformers who campaigned for the first public parks, and (4) _____ what their example means for cities today.

(5) _____ we've seen that the first parks were designed as the "lungs" of the city. (6) _____: who were these parks actually for? (7) _____ we look at the rules posted at their gates.

The lecture's through-line in one sentence: _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 2: REORDER FOR COHERENCE

Put each set in a coherent order and name the ordering principle.

Set A. (a) The result was a treaty that satisfied nobody. (b) In 1919, the victorious powers gathered at Versailles. (c) Each arrived with incompatible aims: security, reparations and self-determination. (d) Within two decades, the grievances it left unresolved had helped ignite a second war.

Order: _____ Principle: _____

Set B. (a) Within a year, three neighboring towns had copied the idea. (b) In 2019, a small-town library began lending tools as well as books. (c) The scheme's success surprised even its organizers. (d) Drills, ladders and sewing machines proved especially popular.

Order: _____ Principle: _____

Which words made the order feel inevitable rather than merely possible? _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 3: IMPROVE THE INFORMATION FLOW

Each paragraph is logical but clumsy: new information keeps landing in the theme position. Rewrite it so each sentence opens on the given and ends on the new.

1. "A leak in the roof was the origin of the trouble. Damage to the archive's oldest manuscripts was the consequence of the leak. A complete overhaul of the building's drainage was the board's eventual response to the damage."

2. "A new timetable was introduced in September. Complaints from parents about the early start were the result of the timetable. A compromise start time of 8:45 was the school's response to the complaints."

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 4: WIRING OR THOUGHT?

Diagnose each passage: a **cohesion** fault, a **coherence** fault, **elegant variation** or **over-signposting**. Then say how you would fix it.

A. "The gallery reopened in March. Similarly, the café serves excellent coffee. Consequently, the exhibition features Dutch masters. Furthermore, tickets are timed."

Diagnosis and fix: _____

B. "The sonata is demanding. The piece tests any pianist; indeed, few tackle the composition in public, and the work's finale defeats all but the finest; the opus is, quite simply, a peak."

Diagnosis and fix: _____

C. "Sales fell. Three senior staff left. The manager was replaced. Profits recovered."

Diagnosis and fix: _____

D. "In this paragraph, I will first begin by introducing the topic of this paragraph, which is sleep. Having introduced sleep, I will now turn to the next part, in which I will discuss sleep."

Diagnosis and fix: _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 5: BUILD THE CHAIN

Build a lexical chain for a **heat wave**, then use it in a three-sentence paragraph. Repeat the anchor at least once.

Repetition	_____
Synonym / near-synonym	_____
Superordinate	_____
General word	_____
Collocations from the same field	_____

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: THE EDITOR'S VERDICT

Ruth: I've read your piece on the pocket forests. The sentences are lovely.

Sam: I sense a "but" coming.

Ruth: You sense correctly. Try the skeleton test: one sentence per paragraph, out loud.

Sam: Fine. The city planted forests. They grew fast. Critics object to the cost. The summer was dry. Supporters reply...

Ruth: Hear that? The drought arrives after the critics, but the drought is what caused the cost they're attacking.

Sam: So it's the order, not the wording.

Ruth: Exactly. No amount of polishing fixes a paragraph that's in the wrong place. And one more thing: in paragraph four you call them "the plantings," "the woodlands," "the green patches" and "the mini-forests."

Sam: I was avoiding repetition.

Ruth: You were avoiding clarity. Pick "pocket forests" and let "they" do the rest.

Which of Sam's problems is cohesion and which is coherence? Practice the dialogue, starting Ruth's key sentences on a higher pitch.

◆ PAIR WORK – COHESION & COHERENCE LAB

Round 1: Reconstruct. Your group holds seven paragraphs of one article. Describe or read aloud your openings and endings before you show anyone your paragraphs.

Our order (letters)	___ → ___ → ___ → ___ → ___ → ___ → ___
Ordering principle	
Clue 1 (a reference)	
Clue 2 (a summary noun)	
Clue 3 (a theme that picks up a rheme)	

Round 2: Diagnose and repair. Log each fault in the broken draft before you rewrite.

Sentence	Fault	Cohesion or coherence?
—		
—		
—		

—		
—		
—		

Our repair (about 120 words):

Round 3: Skeleton test. One sentence per move of the other group's repair. Does it read as one argument?

One strength (quote it)	
One suggestion (quote it)	

◆ SAY – SELF-CHECK: CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

A report is full of connectives (*however, therefore, moreover*), yet the reader finishes it unable to say what it argued. What is most likely missing?

A) Coherence

B) Cohesion

C) Reference

2

Which pair shows the best information flow?

A) The director unveiled a radical proposal. Alarm among her own board was the immediate reaction.

B) The director unveiled a radical proposal. This proposal alarmed her own board.

C) The director unveiled a radical proposal. Board meetings are on Wednesdays.

3

The skeleton of a five-paragraph article reads: "The city planted forty pocket forests. The forests grew fast. Critics say each tree costs too much. The forests grew fast and attracted insects. The council is pleased." What does the skeleton reveal?

A) A cohesion problem: add connectives such as *however* and *moreover*.

B) A coherence problem: a step is repeated, the cause of the extra cost is missing, and the critics get no reply. Reorder and rebuild.

C) Nothing: every sentence is accurate, so the article is sound.

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ tell a cohesion fault from a coherence fault, and fix the right one
- ◆ ☐ open sentences on given information and end them on the new
- ◆ ☐ run a lexical chain through a text and repeat the anchor term instead of disguising it
- ◆ ☐ write topic sentences and signpost the turns, not every step
- ◆ ☐ test a long text with the one-sentence-per-paragraph skeleton

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Write the skeleton of something you wrote (or your new identity card's text). Is its weakness order, relevance or a missing through-line?

◆ READ AND SAY — NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

a précis

the gist

a paraphrase

patchwriting

a synthesis

attribution

a reporting verb

fidelity

proportion

to distort

to over-generalize

to concede

In essence, ...

Boiled down to a sentence, ...

As X points out, ...

X concedes that...

X counters that...

Both X and Y concur that...

Whereas X..., Y...

Y qualifies X's claim, noting...

Taken together, ...

A more nuanced picture emerges when...

patchwriting = keeping a source's sentence structure and swapping in synonyms; it is treated as plagiarism, even with a citation · **fidelity** = faithfulness to what the source actually says, including how certain it is · **proportion** = giving a minor point minor space

◆ GRAMMAR BOX

Summarize	same meaning, far fewer words: delete · generalize · supply a topic sentence · keep the logical relations (<i>although, but, because</i>)
Paraphrase	same meaning, similar length, new structure : change word class · voice · clause order · subject · then, last, words
Synthesize	several sources, one account organized by idea : agree · diverge · qualify · extend

Rebuild, don't re-skin. Original: *The rapid expansion of social media has fundamentally altered the way young people form their political opinions.*

Patchwriting	<i>The quick growth of social media has basically changed the way young individuals develop their political views. (same skeleton, new synonyms)</i>
Genuine paraphrase	<i>Where young people once inherited their politics from family and community, many now form those views through the fast-growing world of social media.</i>

Reporting verbs carry stance.

Neutral	state · note · observe · remark · describe
Committed source	argue · contend · maintain · insist · hold

You lean toward it	point out · show · demonstrate · establish
Reluctant admission	concede · acknowledge · admit · grant
Opposition	counter · dispute · challenge · reject · refute
You doubt it	claim · allege · purport · would have us believe

Use the present tense for what a text says (*Hsu **argues***) and one attribution frame per claim. Weak: *According to Hsu, he argues that...*

◆ LISTEN — EXERCISE 1: THE RADIO PANEL

A radio host sums up a discussion about closing Main Street to cars on weekends. Complete the table.

Speaker	Reporting verb(s)	View
Priya Raman, café owner	_____	_____
Tom Becker, hardware store	_____	_____
Dr. Lee, transport researcher	_____	_____

What do all three agree on? _____

◆ WRITE — EXERCISE 2: ONE-SENTENCE GIST

Reduce each paragraph to one faithful sentence. Keep the logical relation.

1. "The museum's decision to charge admission for the first time in its history was defended by trustees as a regrettable necessity in an age of shrinking public subsidy. Critics, however, protested that a national collection assembled with taxpayers' money ought to remain free to the very public that owns it, and warned that the charge would deter precisely the low-income visitors the museum claims to serve."

2. "Community gardens are often praised as a cheap way to improve city neighborhoods. A three-year study in two cities found that residents near new gardens reported feeling safer and knowing more of their neighbors, and that complaints about vacant lots fell sharply. Yet the same study found that the benefits faded quickly where no one was paid to coordinate the volunteers, and several gardens had closed within two years for that reason."

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 3: PARAPHRASE OR PATCHWRITE?

Label each attempt **P** (genuine paraphrase), **PW** (patchwriting) or **D** (distortion: the meaning has changed). Then repair one PW attempt.

Original 1: *"The company's reluctance to inspect its suppliers has allowed dangerous practices to flourish unchecked."*

A. The firm's unwillingness to examine its vendors has let hazardous practices thrive unrestrained.

B. Because managers have declined to check on the firms they buy from, unsafe methods have been free to spread. _____

Original 2 (Hsu): *"Libraries that have gone fine-free report stable return rates, but the data are drawn largely from their own records, over short periods."*

C. Fine-free libraries say return rates are stable, but the figures come mostly from their own records over brief periods. _____

D. Hsu points out that the evidence of steady returns has mostly been gathered by the libraries themselves, and only for a short time. _____

E. Hsu shows that libraries without fines lose their books. _____

My repair of _____:

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 4: CHOOSE THE REPORTING VERB

Write a reporting verb that matches the stance in brackets.

1. (neutral) Nwosu _____ that several parents avoided the library after a single overdue notice.

2. (a point against the source's own position) Ortega _____ that fines brought in some revenue.

3. (the source is strongly committed) Hsu _____ that the county should fund a pilot first.

4. (you accept the point) As Nwosu _____, transportation and opening hours matter as much as fines.

5. (the source opposes another view) Hsu _____ the idea that abolishing fines costs nothing.

6. (you doubt it and can justify the doubt) The flyer _____ that fine-free libraries "always" lose money.

7. (neutral description + as) Ortega _____ fines as a barrier to the families who most need the library.

8. (one source develops another's point) Nwosu _____ Ortega's point, adding that the fear of fines matters more than fines owed.

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 5: SYNTHESIZE TWO STATEMENTS

Combine each pair into one sentence with fair attribution and a synthesis connector.

1. Voss: "Standardized testing is the only fair, objective measure of what students have actually learned." · Ahmed: "Standardized tests measure little beyond a family's income and a child's skill at sitting exams."

2. Kim: "Open-plan offices encourage the chance conversations from which good ideas grow." · Patel: "Open-plan offices mostly produce noise and interruptions, and people end up emailing colleagues who sit three meters away."

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: A LIST OR A SYNTHESIS?

Luis: Could you look at my synthesis on fine-free libraries before I hand it in?

Nadia: Sure. "Source A says... Source B says... Source C says..." It's accurate, but it's a list.

Luis: How else would I organize it?

Nadia: By idea. Start with what they agree on.

Luis: That fines don't bring in much money... although Hsu wouldn't put it that way. He says "modest but real."

Nadia: Good catch. So even the agreement has to be stated carefully. And here: "Hsu claims the data are unreliable."

Luis: Is that unfair?

Nadia: "Claims" makes you sound doubtful of him. And does he actually say "unreliable"?

Luis: No. He says the data come from the libraries' own records, over short periods.

Nadia: Then "Hsu notes" or "Hsu points out," and report what he actually said.

Find two problems Nadia spots: one of **organization** and one of **fidelity**. Practice the dialogue, stressing the names.

◆ PAIR WORK – SYNTHESIS WORKSHOP

Topic: Should public libraries abolish overdue fines?

Round 1: Experts. Read your source for two minutes, turn it over, and give your group a 30-second gist from memory. Notes on the other two sources (no more than eight words each):

Source _____: _____

Source _____: _____

Round 2: Idea grid.

Where they agree	
Where they diverge	
Where one qualifies or extends another	
Our governing sentence	

Round 3: Write about 200 words (180–220), organized by idea, every claim attributed, nothing borrowed.

Word count: _____

Round 4: Integrity review (your partner's synthesis).

Highlighter test: borrowed runs of 3+ words	number: ____ · lines: _____
"Whose voice?" test: sentences I couldn't label	
Any source made more certain, or less certain, than it is?	
One strength (quote it)	
One suggestion (quote it)	

1

A summary of "Some critics worry the reform may raise costs" reads "The reform is a costly failure." What has gone wrong?

A) It over-generalizes and distorts the source's cautious claim.

B) It is too short to count as a summary.

C) It fails to reword the original.

2

Which is a genuine paraphrase, not patchwriting, of "The scheme's rapid rollout caused widespread confusion"?

A) The scheme's fast launch produced broad bewilderment.

B) The rapid rollout of the scheme caused confusion that was widespread.

C) Because the scheme was introduced so quickly, many people were left unsure how it worked.

3

You want to report Dr. Okafor's finding neutrally, without signaling agreement or doubt. Which do you write?

A) Okafor alleges that the new schedule reduced absences.

B) Okafor notes that the new schedule reduced absences.

C) Okafor would have us believe that the new schedule reduced absences.

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ reduce a dense paragraph to a faithful one-sentence gist that keeps its logic
- ◆ ☐ paraphrase by rebuilding the sentence, and recognize patchwriting in my own work
- ◆ ☐ choose a reporting verb that is fair to the source and honest about my stance
- ◆ ☐ synthesize several sources by idea, not source by source
- ◆ ☐ check a text for borrowed words and distorted claims

Rebuild one sentence from something you once paraphrased (or your new identity card's source) without looking at the original. What changed?

The Complete Communicator: Style & Rhetoric

Three lessons in which command becomes effect. You will learn the named techniques behind persuasion, and the critical armor to resist them when they are used on you; you will listen to the music of your own prose and make every word earn its place; and, at the halfway point of C2, you will orchestrate everything you have refined so far in a single performance, then re-pitch it for a different audience.

Lessons 4.1–4.3

Classes C10–C12

Level C2

Name: _____

HOW THIS MODULE WORKS

Each exercise heading tells you what to do: **Read, Listen, Write, Say** or **Pair work**. Almost every task here has many good answers; judge your work by its effect on a reader or listener, not only by its correctness.

When you argue a case, you argue the card, not necessarily your own conviction. When a task draws on your own experience, you decide what to share: your real life, **or** a new identity card, **or** something you invent. All three are equally valid, and you can always say "Pass."

◆ READ AND SAY — NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

ethos — credibility**pathos** — emotion**logos** — reason,
evidence**tricolon** — a rule of
three—
anaphora repeated
openings—
epistrophe repeated
endings—
antithesis balanced
opposites**chiasmus** — A-B-B-A
mirror— ask,
hypophora then
answer— why
a warrant evidence
counts**a** — a point
concession granted**a** — a point
refutation answered— a
a fallacy counterfeit
argument

As someone who has...

Picture, for a moment,...

The figures are stark:

It follows, then, that...

My contention is simple:

This matters because...

I readily accept that...

There is force in the objection that...

But this overlooks...

That may be so, yet it does not follow that...

That's a false choice, because...

With respect, that attacks me, not my case.

◆ GRAMMAR BOX — THE SHAPES OF PERSUASION

Tricolon	three grammatically parallel elements	Reading sharpens the mind, softens the heart, and widens the world.
Anaphora	the same words open successive clauses	<u>This city deserves</u> schools that lift every child. <u>This city deserves</u> transport that reaches every corner.
Antithesis	contrary ideas in balanced grammar: <i>not X but Y · It is not that...; rather...</i>	This is not a setback; it is an invitation to begin again, wiser.
Rhetorical question	a question asked for effect; the listener supplies the answer	If we do nothing today, what do we tell our children tomorrow?

Chiasmus	the second half mirrors the first (A-B-B-A)	Let us never negotiate out of fear, but let us never fear to negotiate.
-----------------	---	---

The spine of a case. claim → grounds (evidence) → warrant (why it counts) → **concession** (the fair objection, granted narrowly) → **refutation** (why it does not overturn the claim) → restated claim.

Parallelism is the engine. A figure fails when its parts are not grammatically parallel. Weak: *We came to listen, for learning, and so that we could change.* Stronger: *We came to listen, to learn, and to change.*

◆ LISTEN – EXERCISE 1: "LEND IT, DON'T BUY IT"

Your teacher reads a short speech given at a neighborhood meeting by Rosa, a retired carpenter.

a) First listening. What does she propose? Why should we trust her? Which objection does she anticipate?

b) Second listening. Complete each line, then name the figure.

- "For thirty-one years I earned my living with a _____ in my hand." Appeal: _____
- "We buy it, we _____ it once, and we _____ it for a decade." Figure: _____
- "A tool that sits in a garage is not an _____; it is a _____ with a handle." Figure: _____
- "Why does that matter? _____" Figure: _____
- "I'm not asking you to spend _____; I'm asking you to own _____." Figure: _____
- "Share the drill, share the ladder, _____." Figures: _____
- "Isn't that what a _____ is for?" Figure: _____

c) The spine. Number the moves in the order you heard them.

_____ a story about a neighbor _____ the objection granted _____ her credentials
 _____ the survey figures _____ the proposal _____ why the figures matter
 _____ the objection answered _____ the proposal restated

d) The counterfeit. One line in an otherwise honest speech is a fallacy. Write it down and name it.

◆ READ – EXERCISE 2: NAME THE APPEAL AND THE FIGURE

For each extract, write the **dominant appeal** (ethos, pathos or logos) and any **figure** you find. Overlaps are expected: judge by the dominant effect.

1. "I have walked these wards for forty years; I have held the hands you will only read about."

Appeal: _____ Figure: _____

2. "We cannot spend our way to prosperity. We cannot borrow our way to solvency. We cannot pretend our way to security."

Appeal: _____ Figure: _____

3. "The trial found a 34% reduction in cases across three independent cohorts; the effect is real and the mechanism is understood."

Appeal: _____ Figure: _____

4. "Is a society to be judged by how it treats its strongest, or by how it treats its weakest?"

Appeal: _____ Figure: _____

5. "I'll be the first to admit that I once argued the opposite, and I was wrong."

Appeal: _____ Figure: _____

6. "We do not read to pass the time; we read so that time does not pass us by."

Appeal: _____ Figure: _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 3: RECAST A FLAT CLAIM WITH A NAMED FIGURE

Rewrite each claim using the figure in brackets. Keep the grammar parallel. Many answers are possible; judge by whether it lands.

1. (tricolon) "Learning a language as an adult is good for you in several ways."

→ _____

2. (antithesis) "We should prevent problems instead of just reacting to them."

→ _____

3. (anaphora) "This library needs longer hours, more seating, and faster Wi-Fi."

→ _____

4. (rhetorical question) "We shouldn't keep postponing the decision, because it costs us every month."

→ _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 4: NAME THE FALLACY AND COUNTER IT

Choose from: *straw man* · *ad hominem* · *false dilemma* · *slippery slope* · *bandwagon* · *hasty generalization*. Then write a calm one-line counter that redirects to the actual claim.

1. "Either we buy the expensive software or we go back to paper. There's no middle ground."

Fallacy: _____ Counter: _____

2. "Why take cooking advice from her? She's never even run a restaurant."

Fallacy: _____ Counter: _____

3. "If we let staff choose their own hours, soon nobody will turn up at all."

Fallacy: _____ Counter: _____

4. "Everyone in the department uses this spreadsheet template, so it must be the best one."

Fallacy: _____ Counter: _____

5. "I met two engineers who couldn't write a clear email. Engineers can't write."

Fallacy: _____ Counter: _____

6. A: "We could hold fewer meetings." B: "So you think we should never talk to each other? Absurd."

Fallacy: _____ Counter: _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 5: CONCEDE NARROWLY, REFUTE DECISIVELY

Complete each pair. Give up the small ground; hold the large.

1. Claim: *Every office should have one meeting-free afternoon a week.* Objection: *Urgent issues can't wait.*

Concede: I grant that _____

Refute: But _____

2. Claim: *Museums should be free one evening a month.* Objection: *Museums will lose ticket income.*

Concede: There is force in the objection that _____

Refute: That may be so, yet it does not follow that _____

3. Claim: *Recipes should give weights, not cups.* Objection: *Most home cooks don't own a scale.*

Concede: _____

Refute: _____

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: THE MEETING-FREE AFTERNOON

Leila: I want to argue that we protect Wednesday afternoons: no meetings, no exceptions. Our calendars have become a mosaic with no picture.

Marco: I'll grant you the calendars; mine looks like a crossword. But meetings are where decisions get made. Cancel them and the decisions don't vanish; they just wait.

Leila: Admittedly, some decisions can't wait. That said, how many of Wednesday's meetings produced a decision last month? I counted: two out of eleven.

Marco: That's a striking figure. Yet it doesn't follow that the other nine were useless. Some of them were the only time the teams actually spoke.

Leila: Then perhaps the question isn't meetings or no meetings. It's whether we meet because we must, or because we always have.

Marco: Now that's an antithesis I can live with. Suppose we trial it for a month and let the numbers decide?

Find one concession, one refutation, one figure and one piece of logos. Where does the disagreement narrow?

◆ PAIR WORK – THE PERSUASION LAB: PLAN A TWO-MINUTE SPEECH

Draw a topic card and a side card. You argue the card. Draft the **concession first**. Write full sentences only for the opening, the pivot and the close; everything else is notes.

Topic · my side	
Opening (ethos) · written in full	
Claim in one sentence	
Grounds (logos) · notes	
Warrant: this matters because...	
Pivot: concession → refutation · written in full	
Close (pathos + restated claim) · written in full	
My figures (mark T · A · X · RQ)	

The flat-reading test. Read your proudest line in a completely flat voice. Does it still make a claim that holds? If it only works with the performance, question it.

◆ SAY – SELF-CHECK: CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

"Ask not what your country can do for you; ask what you can do for your country." Which pair of figures is at work?

A) Anaphora and climax

B) Tricolon and epistrophe

C) Antithesis and chiasmus

2

"You can't trust his report on energy use; he drives a huge car." Which fallacy is this?

A) False dilemma

B) Ad hominem

C) Slippery slope

3

A neighbor objects that tools lent by a tool library will come back broken. Which reply concedes narrowly and refutes decisively?

A) "You're completely wrong; the library will obviously work."

B) "I grant that some tools may come back damaged; but a small repair fund costs far less than every household buying its own."

C) "You're right, broken tools are a huge problem, so perhaps we shouldn't bother."

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ identify the dominant appeal in an extract and explain why a strong case balances all three
- ◆ ☐ use a tricolon, anaphora, antithesis and a rhetorical question, with parallel grammar and the right rhythm
- ◆ ☐ build a case along the spine, conceding narrowly and refuting decisively
- ◆ ☐ name a fallacy and counter it calmly
- ◆ ☐ tell when high rhetoric fits the occasion, and when it grates

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Quote one persuasive line you met this week (an advertisement, a speech, a meeting). Name its appeal and its figure, and say whether it survives the flat-reading test.

◆ READ AND SAY – NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

style — consistent choices	— the voice personality heard	cadence — the rise and fall	a periodic sentence — point held back
a loose sentence — point first	a fragment — a deliberate part	— words deadwood that earn nothing	a smothered verb — a verb buried in a noun
telegram prose — cut too far	purple prose — over-ornamented	pastiche — imitation of a manner	a darling — a line you love too much

omit needless words

cut the dead, keep the living

free the verb

read it aloud

the short sentence after the long

land on a strong word

imitate, then diverge

kill your darlings

drafting discovers; editing decides

◆ GRAMMAR BOX – SHAPE, ECONOMY AND STRENGTH

Simple	The room fell silent.
Compound	She spoke, and the room fell silent.
Complex	When she spoke, the room fell silent.
Periodic	When she rose, when she drew breath, when at last she spoke, the room fell silent.
Loose	The room fell silent, all argument spent, every eye turned toward her.

Deadwood	Cure	Smothered verb	Freed
each and every · first and foremost	every · first	make a decision	decide
very unique · really important	unique · important	give consideration to	consider
It is important to note that...	(just say it)	conduct an investigation into	investigate

due to the fact that · at this point in time	because · now	provide assistance to	help
it seems that perhaps it might possibly...	one hedge	put forward a suggestion	suggest

Economy is not terseness. Every word should earn its place; that does not mean using as few as possible. A long sentence can be perfectly economical, and a short one can be flabby.

◆ LISTEN – EXERCISE 1: ONE FIRE DRILL, THREE VOICES

A fire drill interrupts a budget meeting. Your teacher reads three versions: A, B and C. Tick the features you hear in each.

Feature	A	B	C
exact times and numbers	☐	☐	☐
impersonal (no "I" or "we")	☐	☐	☐
a periodic sentence	☐	☐	☐
a metaphor or simile	☐	☐	☐
a deliberate fragment	☐	☐	☐
understatement or irony	☐	☐	☐
a twist in the final words	☐	☐	☐

Give each writer a name that captures the voice: A _____ B _____ C _____

◆ READ – EXERCISE 2: NAME THE SHAPE

Write **simple**, **compound**, **complex**, **periodic** or **loose**.

1. The market closed early, the stalls half-packed, the last customers drifting off with their bags.

2. Nobody came. _____

3. Although the forecast was clear, the ferry was canceled. _____

4. After the delays, after the apologies, after three hours on a cold platform, the train arrived. _____

5. The lights went out, and the orchestra kept playing. _____

Which one would you place straight after a very long sentence, and why? _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 3: CUT TO THE LEAN, GRACEFUL FORM

Trim each sentence to its essential core. Cut the deadwood and free the verbs, but do not go terse.

1. It is important to note that, in the event that the weather turns bad, we will make the decision to cancel the event.

→ _____

2. Due to the fact that she had a very great amount of experience, she was able to provide assistance to the newer members of the team.

→ _____

3. At this point in time, each and every one of the applicants is required to submit a full and complete application.

→ _____

4. What I would like to say is that it seems that perhaps the report might possibly contain some errors of a factual nature.

→ _____

5. The committee will conduct a review of the proposal and then put forward a recommendation with regard to its future.

→ _____

◆ WRITE — EXERCISE 4: GIVE A MONOTONE PASSAGE ITS MUSIC

Every sentence below has the same length and shape. Rewrite it with genuine variety: at least one long, accumulating sentence and one short sentence or fragment for impact. Keep every fact.

The market opened at seven. The stalls were full of fruit. The sellers shouted their prices. The air smelled of bread and coffee. A small boy was holding his father's hand. He pointed at a pile of oranges. The pile fell over. Everyone laughed.

Read both versions aloud. Where did your voice speed up, and where did it slow down?

◆ READ — EXERCISE 5: VOICE FINGERPRINTS

Match each passage to a voice: **the Reporter**, **the Lyric Essayist** or **the Deadpan Wit**. Underline two features that gave it away.

1. "The 8:15 ferry to the island was canceled at 7:50 because of high winds. Forty passengers were offered refunds. Service resumed at noon." _____

2. "The ferry, we were told, was canceled owing to wind. There was, I should say, some wind. Several of us have since recovered our hats." _____

3. "Out on the gray water, where the ferry should have been, the wind was writing something long and furious on the waves. We stood on the pier and tried to read it. We never did." _____

Now write one sentence about the same ferry in a voice of your own. _____

◆ READ AND SAY — DIALOGUE: KILLING A DARLING

Ines: Would you read my opening? It's for the library newsletter. I'm rather proud of the second sentence.

Karim: "The library, that patient cathedral of the unhurried mind, reopened on Monday." Hmm. It's lovely.

Ines: But?

Karim: Would you like a suggestion? The rest of the piece is warm and plain. Then there's this cathedral. It sounds like a different writer.

Ines: So it's a darling.

Karim: I think so. What if the second sentence just said what people found? "The chairs are new. The quiet is not."

Ines: Oh, that's better. Shorter, and it sounds like me. Thank you. I'll save the cathedral for something grander.

How does Karim offer the critique? Which line is the darling, and why does the replacement work better for this reader?

◆ PAIR WORK — STYLE & VOICE WORKSHOP: ONE EVENT, THREE VOICES

Your event card: _____. Keep the facts identical; change only the telling. About 50–70 words each.

1. The Reporter ☐ exact times and numbers ☐ short declaratives ☐ no opinion adjectives ☐ impersonal

2. The Lyric Essayist ☐ first person ☐ one periodic sentence ☐ one image ☐ a quiet closing line

3. The Deadpan Wit ☐ understatement or irony ☐ flat tone ☐ the twist in the last words ☐ never explains the joke

Critique Circle notes. Blind reading, then: what stayed with us → my question → neutral questions → one darling, one fix (with permission).

The voice they guessed first, and why	
A phrase that stayed with a critic (quote it)	
My question to the group	
A possible darling (quote it)	
One fix I will make	

◆ SAY – SELF-CHECK: CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

Which is the most economical yet still graceful revision of "Due to the fact that we had reached a decision, we made an announcement to the public"?

A) Having decided, we announced it publicly.

B) Decision. Announcement.

C) Because we had reached a decision, we made a public announcement.

2

You've written five medium-length sentences in a row and the paragraph plods. What is the classic rhythm fix?

- A) Replace the plain words with more impressive, longer synonyms.
- B) Add several adjectives to each sentence to make them richer.
- C) Break the monotony: fuse a couple into one longer sentence and drop in a short one for impact.

3

"At this point in time, it is really important to note that each and every volunteer should, if at all possible, arrive early." Which revision cuts the deadwood without going terse?

- A) Volunteers: early.
- B) Every volunteer should arrive early if possible.
- C) Now, importantly, every single volunteer should really try to arrive early.

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ explain style as consistent choices and voice as the personality they project
- ◆ ☐ vary sentence length and shape on purpose, including periodic and loose sentences and a deliberate short sentence
- ◆ ☐ cut deadwood and free smothered verbs without going terse
- ◆ ☐ sustain three distinct voices for the same event
- ◆ ☐ give and receive precise, quoted critique, and kill a darling

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

What did the Critique Circle tell you about your own voice? Name one habit of your writing you intend to keep, and one you intend to break.

TODAY'S TASK

You will give a **three-minute speech** to a small group, take **two minutes of unscripted questions**, and then **re-pitch** the same argument in writing for a different reader. Your teacher listens and reads with a checklist. It is not a test: it shows you, and your teacher, what you already orchestrate well and what to sharpen before Progress Test 1.

◆ READ AND SAY — THE ORCHESTRATION TOOLKIT

Module 1	the mot juste · register and tone · fixed expressions and strong collocations	not "very tired" but <i>spent</i> · <i>by and large</i> · <i>part and parcel</i>
Module 2	implicature · irony and understatement · metaphor	<i>It was, shall we say, memorable.</i> · <i>Her argument was a fortress.</i>
Module 3	stance markers · cohesion and signposting · summary and synthesis	<i>Admittedly,... that said,...</i> · <i>Such objections, however,...</i> · <i>While X stresses..., Y counters that...</i>
Module 4	appeals, figures, concession · rhythm, economy, voice	<i>not to spend more, but to own less</i> · long, long... then short

To my mind, the real question is...

It would be naive to suppose that...

Let me put my cards on the table.

Granted, and yet...

Which brings me to my real point...

If I read your question rightly,...

Let me answer the question beneath the question.

I take your point, and I'd go further...

Let me leave you with this.

◆ LISTEN — EXERCISE 1: A DECISION LOG FOR EVERY TEAM

Your teacher reads a short speech by Daniel, a hospital pharmacist, followed by two questions.

a) **The arc.** Note the words of the hook, the turn and the landing.

Hook	
Turn (concession)	
Landing	

b) **The layers.** Tick what you hear and note the words.

- ☐ a mot juste _____ ☐ a register shift _____ ☐ a fixed expression _____
- ☐ understatement _____ ☐ a metaphor _____ ☐ a stance marker _____
- ☐ ethos _____ ☐ logos _____ ☐ a tricolon _____

c) **The Q&A.** How does Daniel show that he has understood each question before he answers it? What is "the question beneath the question" in the second one?

◆ READ – EXERCISE 2: NAME THE MASTERY MOVE

Name the chief device at work in each line.

1. "The scheme was, shall we say, optimistic." (of a scheme that collapsed) _____
2. "For all its flaws, and there are many, the plan has one virtue its rivals lack." _____
3. "An argument is not won by the loudest voice, but by the last one still standing when the shouting stops." _____
4. "Well, she certainly has a lot of energy; I'll give her that much." _____
5. "Across these three reports, one thread recurs: incentives, not intentions, drive the outcome." _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 3: LAYER UP A FLAT LINE

Rewrite each flat sentence with at least **three** layers (for example a stance marker, a mot juste, a figure and a weighted final phrase). Then label your layers.

1. "I think constant notifications are bad for concentration because they interrupt us."

→ _____

Layers: _____

2. "Good teachers are important, and we don't value them enough."

→ _____

Layers: _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 4: ONE IDEA, TWO ROOMS

Re-pitch each idea twice: once for an expert, formal, written room, and once for a lay, informal, spoken room. Change register, density, idiom and rhetoric together.

1. *Regular breaks improve the accuracy of data entry.*

Expert: _____

Lay: _____

2. *Reading aloud to young children builds their vocabulary.*

Expert: _____

Lay: _____

◆ READ – EXERCISE 5: JUDGE THE ADAPTATION

For each occasion, choose the opening that reads the room better, and say why in a few words.

1. A farewell for a colleague retiring after thirty years.

A) "Statistically, retirement is associated with a measurable decline in social contact, which I will now outline."

B) "Thirty years. There is no speech long enough, so let me give you a short one and a long thank-you."

Better: _____ because _____

2. A briefing for a funding panel of scientists.

A) "Picture a world where every child can read, a world of wonder, a world of hope!"

B) "Our pilot raised reading scores by eleven percent across four schools; I'd like to explain why we think it will scale." Better: _____ because _____

3. A welcome for new volunteers at a community garden.

A) "Welcome. Pursuant to our volunteer policy, attendance at induction is mandatory."

B) "Welcome, and thank you for giving up a Saturday. By the end of today you'll know where everything is, including the good gloves." Better: _____ because _____

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: THE QUESTION BENEATH THE QUESTION

Amara: So your claim is that museums should let visitors handle replicas. Isn't there a risk that it turns a museum into a playground?

Joel: If I read your question rightly, the worry is about seriousness, not breakage. That's a fair challenge.

Amara: Exactly. A museum isn't a toy shop.

Joel: Granted, and yet the most serious scholars I know learned by handling things. What I'd say is this: touch doesn't make the encounter less serious; it makes it more memorable.

Amara: Memorable for whom, though? The children, or the parents who have to supervise them?

Joel: For both, ideally. But I take your point, and I'd go further: it needs staff, not just a table of replicas. That's part and parcel of doing it properly.

How does Joel paraphrase, concede and counter? Where does he answer the question beneath the question?

◆ PAIR WORK – SPEECH PLANNER

Notes only, except the hook and the last line. Three minutes, then two minutes of questions.

Topic · my side

Hook (written in full)	
Claim in one sentence	
Grounds + warrant	
Turn: concession → refutation	
Landing (last line written in full)	

My layers (plan six; circle the one you keep in reserve):

- ☐ mot juste _____
 ☐ register shift _____
 ☐ fixed expression _____
 ☐ implicature / understatement _____
☐ figure _____
 ☐ stance marker _____
 ☐ appeal _____

Two questions I expect, and my first answer:

◆ **WRITE — THE WRITTEN RE-PITCH (150–180 WORDS)**

My audience card: _____. Write the same argument for **this** reader. Include the strongest challenge from your Q&A, reported fairly (*One colleague questioned whether... · It was objected that...*), and your answer.

Re-pitch check (your partner): ☐ this reader could act on it ☐ register consistent for this reader ☐ the challenge reported fairly ☐ no deadwood

A line that fits this reader perfectly: _____

A line that still belongs to the old room: _____

◆ SAY – MY MASTERY RUBRIC (SCORE 1–5)

5 = indistinguishable from an educated, articulate speaker at their best. Record or draft, step away, then judge.

Dimension	Score	Evidence (quote yourself)
Precision & appropriacy of vocabulary		
Register & tone control		
Idiomatic naturalness		
Cohesion & coherence		
Nuance & implication		
Rhetorical & stylistic effect		
Fluency & spontaneity (the Q&A)		
Accuracy		

Two strengths, with examples: _____

One refinement, with an example: _____

◆ SAY – SELF-CHECK: CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

You must present the same technical finding to a specialist panel and, an hour later, to a general public audience. Which best describes the masterful adaptation?

A) Deliver the identical script both times; the content is what matters.

B) Keep the substance, but re-pitch register, density, idiom and rhetoric for each room.

C) Simplify crudely for the public and pile on jargon for the experts to impress them.

2

"Their generosity, if we can call it that, extended to a single, grudging cup of tea." Which move is doing the most work?

A) Irony and understatement (with a stance hedge)

B) Extended metaphor

C) Summary and synthesis

3

Your speech ended with "Honestly, it's a no-brainer." You are now re-pitching the argument as a briefing note for a hospital board. Which is the best re-pitch?

A) Honestly, it's a no-brainer.

B) The benefits would appear to outweigh the modest costs involved.

C) It's a total no-brainer, to be honest with you.

◆ I CAN... (MODULE 4)

- ◆ ☐ structure a three-minute speech with a hook, a turn and a landing
- ◆ ☐ orchestrate six layers from Modules 1–4 without letting them show off
- ◆ ☐ paraphrase a question, answer the question beneath it, and concede before countering
- ◆ ☐ re-pitch the same argument in writing for a different reader, reporting a challenge fairly
- ◆ ☐ assess my own performance with specific evidence: two strengths and one refinement

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Write the opening of a letter to the person you were at the start of your English journey, **or** to a learner who is just starting out: one thing that changed, and one thing that was worth it.

Interpreting the Real World

Three lessons that take you beyond the English of textbooks. Tune your ear to the world's Englishes and talk about accents with precision and respect. Read a demanding literary text slowly enough to hear what it is doing, and defend your reading with the words on the page. Then speed back up: slang, headlines, memes, allusions, fast speech and sarcasm, with strategies for the part that sails past you.

Lessons 5.1–5.3

Classes C14–C16

Level C2

Name: _____

HOW THIS MODULE WORKS

Each heading tells you what to do: **Read, Listen, Write, Say, Pair work** or **Group work**. Many tasks here are interpretive: more than one answer can be right, provided you can point to the evidence for it.

Two ground rules for this module. First, **no one will ever be asked to perform, imitate or be judged on an accent**, yours or anyone else's; we listen to varieties, we don't act them. Second, when a task draws on your own experience (your English, your media habits), you decide what to share: your real life, a new identity card, or something you invent. All three are equally good, and you can always say "Pass."

◆ MY GOAL AFTER PROGRESS TEST 1

I want to refine _____

Every week I will _____

◆ READ AND SAY — NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

a variety of English an accent a dialect rhotic / non-rhotic t-flapping a glottal stop
 stress-timed / syllable-timed a lingua franca World Englishes a false friend
 intelligibility accommodation to tune in to to decompose an accent into features
 assume variety, not error an accent I'm less familiar with accent bias to place a speaker

rhotic = pronouncing the *r* after a vowel (*car, hard*) · **intelligibility** = being understood by your listener, whatever your accent · **accommodation** = adjusting your speech (and your listening) to meet another speaker halfway · **a false friend** = a word that exists in two varieties with different meanings

◆ GRAMMAR BOX — HEARING AND NAMING VARIETY

Listen for features, not "an accent."

The <i>r</i>	rhotic : <i>car, hard</i> with the <i>r</i> sounded (most of the US, Canada, Scotland, Ireland) · non-rhotic : "cah," "hahd" (southern England, Australia)
The vowel in <i>bath</i>	broad "ah" (southern England, Australia) · short, flat <i>a</i> (US, northern England)
The <i>t</i>	flap : <i>water</i> ≈ "wader" (US, Canada) · glottal stop : <i>butter</i> ≈ "bu'er" (London, much of England) · crisp <i>t</i> elsewhere
The rhythm	stress-timed : strong beats, squeezed syllables (US, UK) · syllable-timed : even syllables (India, Nigeria, Singapore)

Words, spelling and grammar that place a speaker or a writer.

Vocabulary	lift / elevator · flat / apartment · queue / line · trousers / pants · mobile / cell phone · the bill / the check · football / soccer · garden / yard
False friends	first floor (UK: one flight up · US: street level) · table a proposal (UK: discuss it now · US: postpone it) · quite good (UK: fairly good · US: very good) · momentarily (US: very soon · UK: briefly) · homely (UK: cozy · US: plain-looking)
Spelling	colour / color · centre / center · defence / defense · travelled / traveled · catalogue / catalog · organise or organize (both British) → one variety per document

**Grammar
tells**

Have you got a minute? / Do you have a minute? · The committee are... / The committee is... · Have you eaten yet? / Did you eat yet? · got / gotten

World Englishes are established standards, not learner errors: *prepone, do the needful, out of station* (India) · *go-slow, no wahala* (Nigeria) · *comfort room* (the Philippines) · *can or not?* (Singapore) · *arvo, heaps* (Australia).

Language that locates the fault. Not: *He has a heavy accent. · She speaks broken English.* Instead: *He has an accent I'm less familiar with. · It took me a minute to tune in.*

◆ LISTEN – EXERCISE 1: THE DELAYED TRAIN

Your teacher reads a short scene in which five friends from different parts of the English-speaking world wait for a delayed train. The teacher reads every line in their own voice; listen for the words and grammar. Write the word or phrase each speaker uses.

1. Priya's emphasis marker, meaning roughly "just" (Indian English) _____
2. Priya's courteous word for "please" _____
3. Callum's word for "small" (Scottish) _____
4. Callum's word for "know" _____
5. Maddie's word for "afternoon" (Australian) _____
6. Maddie's word for "a cup of tea" _____
7. Chidi's word for a traffic jam (Nigerian English) _____
8. Chidi's phrase for "no problem" _____
9. Ray's word for what a British speaker calls a "lift" (American) _____

Pair work: which three items would most confuse a listener meeting that variety for the first time? How would context help?

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 2: TWO ENGLISHES, ONE MEANING

Complete each sentence with the equivalent word from the other variety. Where the word is a false friend, explain the trap.

1. A British visitor asks for the *lift*; the American host points to the _____.
2. In London you stand in a *queue*; in Chicago you stand in _____.
3. A Briton fills up with *petrol*; an American fills up with _____.
4. A British *mobile* is an American _____.
5. At the end of a meal, a Briton asks for the *bill*; an American usually asks for the _____.
6. A British *garden* behind a house is usually an American _____.

7. "Your office is on the first floor." For a Briton, how many flights of stairs? _____ For an American?

8. A British manager writes, "We'll table your proposal on Monday." An American reads it as bad news. Why?

9. A British reviewer calls your report "quite good." An American might be delighted. What might the reviewer actually mean? _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 3: NAME THE FEATURE

Write the term: *rhotic* · *non-rhotic* · *t-flapping* · *glottal stop* · *broad bath vowel* · *syllable-timed*.

1. *Car* and *farmer* are pronounced with a clearly sounded r. _____

2. *Better* sounds like "bedder" and *city* like "ciddy." _____

3. *Bottle* has a small catch in the throat where the t would be. _____

4. *Hard* sounds like "hahd," with no r at all. _____

5. *Dance* and *can't* have a long "ah," as in "dahnce." _____

6. Each syllable receives nearly equal length and weight, giving an even, measured rhythm.

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 4: ONE DOCUMENT, ONE VARIETY

This notice for an American community center drifts between British and American English. Underline the nine British forms (spelling, vocabulary and grammar), then write the American form above each.

Our new program centre opens in the autumn. Members who have travelled to the old building should note that the car park is now behind the theatre. Please organize your visit in advance: the committee are still finalising the timetable, and we haven't gotten the new catalogue yet. Colour-coded maps will be available at reception.

Which word is correct in both varieties, and why might a British editor keep it? _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 5: PUT THE RESPONSIBILITY WHERE IT BELONGS

Each sentence locates the difficulty in the speaker. Rewrite it so it describes the listener's experience, precisely and respectfully.

1. "Her accent is too heavy to follow."

→ _____

2. "He speaks broken English, but he's a good engineer."

→ _____

3. "Indian English is just incorrect British English."

→ _____

4. "Could you speak normally, please?"

→ _____

5. "She has no accent: she speaks perfect English."

→ _____

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: TABLED

Dana: I just got an email from the London office. They say they'll "table our proposal" on Monday. So that's it, then: they're shelving it.

Arjun: Hang on. In British English, tabling something means putting it on the agenda. They're going to *discuss* it on Monday.

Dana: Seriously? Here it means the opposite. We'd table something to kill it politely.

Arjun: Exactly: same word, opposite plan. And look, they also say the draft is "quite good."

Dana: Which, from them, is... lukewarm?

Arjun: Probably "decent, but it needs work." Mind you, I wouldn't bet on it either way; it depends on the writer.

Dana: So what do we do? I'd rather not guess.

Arjun: Accommodate. Reply in plain international English: "Great, we look forward to discussing it on Monday. Is there anything you'd like us to revise first?"

Dana: No idioms, no ambiguity, and a question that invites them to be specific. I like it.

Find the two false friends. Which sentence is the accommodation strategy? Why does Arjun hedge ("Probably... Mind you...")?

◆ GROUP WORK – VARIETIES LAB

Round 1: Feature Detective. Your group receives two unlabeled transcripts. For each one, record every variety feature and the evidence for your placement.

Word or structure	Meaning in American English	Sound features (from the note)	Variety + evidence

--	--	--	--

Peer check, "Evidence or assumption?": ☐ every placement cites a word, a structure or a described sound
 · ☐ no placement rests on "it just sounds like..." · ☐ every feature is described as variety, never as error

Round 2: Transatlantic info gap. Partner A has a British colleague's welcome email; Partner B has an American visitor's questions. Without showing the page, find six places an American reader could misunderstand.

Round 3: Attitudes. Discuss three attitude cards: agree, disagree, or "it depends," with a reason. We are discussing ideas, not anyone's accent. Personal stories are optional.

Our most interesting insight	
A reframe the monitor suggested	

◆ SAY – SELF-CHECK: CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

A speaker pronounces the *r* in *car* and *hard*, and taps the *t* in *water* so it sounds like "wader." Which variety are they most likely speaking?

A) American English

B) Southern British (RP)

C) Australian English

2

You hear a speaker say "The committee are still arguing" and "Have you got the post?" Which is the best conclusion?

A) The speaker has made two grammar mistakes.

B) The speaker is a non-native learner making errors.

C) These are standard British English features: variety, not error.

3

A colleague in Lagos messages: "There's a serious go-slow on the expressway, so I'll reach by ten."
What does she mean?

A) Workers on the expressway are protesting by working slowly, and she has made an error with "reach."

B) The traffic is badly jammed, so she will arrive by ten.

C) She is driving slowly on purpose and may not arrive at all.

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ decompose an unfamiliar accent into features: the r, the t, the *bath* vowel, the rhythm
- ◆ ☐ recognize British and American vocabulary, spelling and grammar, and the false friends between them
- ◆ ☐ keep one variety consistent throughout a document
- ◆ ☐ explain why World Englishes are established varieties, not errors
- ◆ ☐ discuss accents and accent bias precisely and respectfully

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Which variety of English is hardest for you to follow, and which features make it so? Which variety has shaped your own English? (Your own story, or a new identity card.)

◆ READ AND SAY — NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

subject theme authorial purpose tone narrative voice point of view

an unreliable narrator allusion imagery symbolism irony juxtaposition

foreshadowing a motif an extended metaphor a periodic sentence

the passage evokes... the image juxtaposes X and Y this detail foreshadows...

the tone shifts from... to... the effect is to... which suggests / reinforces...

it is heavy with irony I'd read it slightly differently Where does it say that?

theme = the underlying concern a text keeps returning to (not what happens) · **an unreliable narrator** = a narrator whose account we come to doubt · **a periodic sentence** = a sentence that delays its main clause until the end

◆ GRAMMAR BOX — READING FOR MEANING, READING HARD SENTENCES

Subject	What literally happens? · <i>a father and son spend a day fishing</i>
Theme	What is it really about? A specific, arguable claim · <i>love that cannot be spoken aloud</i>
Purpose	What does it want to do to the reader? · to move, persuade, unsettle, satirize, mourn
Tone	What is the author's attitude? · affectionate, ironic, elegiac, detached

Strip → spine → restore → paraphrase.

Strip	Bracket the extras: relative clauses, participle phrases, asides between commas or dashes.
Spine	Find the subject and the main verb: who does what?
Restore	Put the pieces back one by one; pin each pronoun to its referent.
Paraphrase	Say the whole thing in one plain sentence.

Watch for **inversion** (*And sore must be the storm* = the storm must be sore), **verbless sentences** used for effect (*Fog everywhere.*) and **archaic meanings** (*wanted wear* = lacked wear).

The engine of interpretation: the text does X (technique) → which creates Y (effect) → which serves Z (theme). A label on its own ("there is imagery") is not yet an interpretation.

◆ LISTEN — EXERCISE 1: A SEMINAR CONTRIBUTION

Your teacher reads one learner's contribution to a seminar on Emily Dickinson's poem "Hope is the thing with feathers." Complete the phrases of literary discussion.

"Dickinson builds the whole poem on an (1) _____: hope is a small bird living in the soul. The first stanza (2) _____ something tireless, a song 'without the words' that never stops. The second stanza (3) _____ the 'little bird' and the 'storm,' and (4) _____ make hope seem fragile and unbreakable at the same time. Notice the (5) _____ in 'sore must be the storm': the delay puts the weight on 'sore.' Then (6) _____ from praise to something more personal in the last stanza. (7) _____ that the final line is the key: hope gives everything and asks nothing, not even 'a crumb.'"

Pair work: which claim has the strongest evidence? Which would you challenge?

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 2: FROM TECHNIQUE TO EFFECT

Name the technique (*allusion · foreshadowing · irony · juxtaposition · symbolism · motif*), then write its effect in one clause.

1. Early in a story, a character jokes that the old bridge "won't last another winter." _____ → the effect is to _____
2. A narrator calls a ruthless businessman "a man of the most delicate conscience." _____ → the effect is to _____
3. A novel keeps returning to images of locked doors. _____ → the effect is to _____
4. A poem places a child's laughter beside a hospital's silent corridor. _____ → the effect is to _____
5. An essay calls a risky new policy "a Pandora's box." _____ → the effect is to _____
6. In a story, a wilting plant on the windowsill comes to stand for a failing marriage. _____ → the effect is to _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 3: UNPICK THE SENTENCE

Strip each sentence to its spine, then paraphrase it in one plain sentence.

1. *"I went to the woods because I wished to live deliberately, to front only the essential facts of life, and see if I could not learn what it had to teach, and not, when I came to die, discover that I had not lived."* (Thoreau, *Walden*, 1854)

Spine: _____

Paraphrase: _____

2. *"And sore must be the storm / That could abash the little bird / That kept so many warm."* (Dickinson, published 1891)

Spine: _____

Paraphrase: _____

3. *"However little known the feelings or views of such a man may be on his first entering a neighbourhood, this truth is so well fixed in the minds of the surrounding families, that he is considered as the rightful property of some one or other of their daughters."* (Austen, *Pride and Prejudice*, 1813)

Spine: _____

Paraphrase: _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 4: IS IT A THEME?

Label each statement S (subject), M (a bland moral) or T (an arguable theme). Then improve one S or M into a T.

1. "The story is about a family dinner." _____

2. "The poem teaches us that we should always be kind." _____

3. "The novel presents ambition as a hunger that grows the more it is fed." _____

4. "The passage is about fog in London." _____

5. "The story suggests that politeness can be a way of avoiding intimacy." _____

My improved version: _____

◆ READ – EXERCISE 5: TWO ROADS

These stanzas come from Robert Frost's "The Road Not Taken" (1916). The speaker has stopped where a path divides in a wood.

*Then took the other, as just as fair,
And having perhaps the better claim,
Because it was grassy and wanted wear;
Though as for that the passing there
Had worn them really about the same,
And both that morning equally lay
In leaves no step had trodden black.
Oh, I kept the first for another day!
Yet knowing how way leads on to way,
I doubted if I should ever come back.
I shall be telling this with a sigh
Somewhere ages and ages hence:
Two roads diverged in a wood, and I—
I took the one less traveled by,
And that has made all the difference.*

1. Which lines suggest the two roads were, in fact, much the same? _____
2. Many readers treat the last stanza as a celebration of choosing the unconventional path. What complicates that reading? _____
3. Why might the speaker "sigh"? Give two possible readings. _____
4. Write one arguable theme sentence for the poem. _____

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: A FRIENDLY DISAGREEMENT

Lina: For me, the Frost poem is about courage: he takes the road less traveled, and it changes his life.

Tomás: I'd read it slightly differently. Look at the second stanza: the paths had been worn "really about the same."

Lina: Fair point. So the difference isn't in the roads.

Tomás: Right. It's in the story he'll tell later. "I shall be telling this with a sigh / Somewhere ages and ages hence." The future tense matters.

Lina: But couldn't the sigh be nostalgic rather than ironic?

Tomás: It could. The poem sustains both, which is partly why it's so often misquoted.

Lina: Then maybe the theme is how we turn chance into a story about choice.

Tomás: Now that I'd sign. And every word of it is answerable to the text.

Underline the phrases the speakers use to disagree politely and to concede. How does Lina's final theme differ from her first?

◆ GROUP WORK – CLOSE-READING SEMINAR

Round 1: Annotate. Read your text three times: for the surface, slowly for word choice, then quietly aloud for rhythm. Annotate: underline images · circle key and repeated words · [bracket] interruptions · draw arrows from pronouns to referents · write ? beside anything uncertain.

Our arguable theme: _____

Our chain: the text does _____

which creates _____

which serves the theme of _____

Evidence (quote): _____

Round 2: Seminar. My role: ☐ discussion leader (speaks last) · ☐ evidence keeper · ☐ alternative reader · ☐ connector · ☐ contributor

Round 3: "Show me the words." Review the other group's theme and chain.

One strength (quote it)	
-------------------------	--

One suggestion (quote it)

◆ SAY – SELF-CHECK: CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

A story's subject is a family dinner; it keeps returning to unspoken resentment and the things no one will say. What is its theme?

- A) A family eating dinner together
- B) The failure of communication within a family
- C) Families should always be kind

2

A first-person narrator repeatedly insists on his own honesty while the events he describes suggest otherwise. This is best described as...

- A) an unreliable narrator
- B) an omniscient narrator
- C) an allusion

3

Pride and Prejudice opens: "It is a truth universally acknowledged, that a single man in possession of a good fortune must be in want of a wife." What is the best reading?

- A) Austen sincerely believes that every wealthy man wants to marry.
- B) It is ironic: the "universal truth" is really the local families' wish to marry their daughters to a rich man.
- C) It is an allusion to a philosophical treatise on marriage.

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ distinguish subject, theme, purpose and tone, and state a theme as an arguable claim
- ◆ ☐ hear narrative voice, detect an unreliable or ironic narrator, and keep narrator and author apart
- ◆ ☐ unpick a difficult sentence: strip, spine, restore, paraphrase
- ◆ ☐ turn a technique into an effect and an effect into a theme

- ◆ ☐ defend and revise a reading in a seminar, quoting the text for every claim

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Name a passage (from any language) that resisted an easy reading. What opened up when you slowed down?

◆ READ AND SAY — NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

slang

register

currency (of a word)

dated

in-group

a cultural reference

an allusion

an in-joke

headlinese

a pun

a meme

connected speech

a reduction

deadpan

sarcasm

ride the gist

it went over my head

Sorry, is that a reference to something?

I think I missed the joke

you had to be there

long story short

that tracks

it is what it is

currency (of a word) = how current it is: fresh, established or dated · **headlinese** = the compressed grammar of headlines · **deadpan** = delivering something absurd with a completely straight face

◆ GRAMMAR BOX — DECODING FAST, COMPRESSED AND LOADED ENGLISH

Slang has a date and a room.

Dated	groovy (1960s–70s) · rad (1980s) · da bomb (1990s) · on fleek (2010s): now retro or ironic
Established informal	to ghost someone · the vibe · to binge-watch · FOMO · a hot take · (British) gutted, knackered: widely understood, still informal
Current	no cap · it slaps · lowkey / highkey · the ick · main-character energy: understand them; use them sparingly, and never in formal writing

Headlinese.

No articles, no be	COUNCIL BACKS BIKE LANES = The council has backed the bike lanes.
Present simple = past	MUSEUM FINDS LOST PAINTING = The museum has found / found...
to + infinitive = future	MAYOR TO UNVEIL PARK PLAN = The mayor will unveil...
Past participle = passive	LIBRARY FINES AXED = Library fines have been abolished.
Short verbs	axe (cut) · back (support) · probe (investigate) · slam (criticize) · vow (promise) · bid (attempt) · eye (consider)

Fast connected speech.

Elision · assimilation · linking	nex(t) day · tem bikes · an apple → "a-napple"
Weak forms	fish 'n' chips · going tuh · a cup uh tea
Reductions	gonna · wanna · gotta · kinda · lemme · dunno · whatcha (what are you) · didja (did you) · wouldja (would you) · shoulda (should have)

Tone over text. When the words and the situation disagree, trust the situation and the delivery: "Well, this is going great" as the car breaks down means the opposite.

◆ LISTEN – EXERCISE 1: THE COFFEE-SHOP RUN-IN

Your teacher reads a fast, casual exchange between two friends, Jordan and Sam. Answer the questions.

1. Who did Jordan run into, and where? _____
2. What does Sam mean by "he'd ghosted the whole group"? _____
3. When Jordan says "cool cool cool, no worries," was Jordan relaxed? How do you know?

4. "Ten bucks says he's back in the group chat by Friday." What does "ten bucks says" mean?

5. What does "no cap" mean? _____
6. What was "the birthday thing"? What can you infer, and what can't you know?

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 2: HEADLINES

Rewrite each invented headline as a full sentence. Then explain the pun or double meaning in 5 and 6.

1. CITY HALL GIVES GREEN LIGHT TO NIGHT BUSES
→ _____
2. SCIENTISTS PROBE MYSTERY SIGNAL
→ _____
3. MUSEUM TO OPEN NEW WING IN SPRING
→ _____
4. LIBRARY FINES AXED
→ _____
5. CHEF GRILLS MAYOR OVER FOOD-TRUCK RULES
→ _____

6. LOCAL BAKERS RISE TO THE CHALLENGE

→ _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 3: WHICH ROOM?

Circle the most appropriate option for each context.

1. A text to a close friend about a concert: **a)** The concert was highly satisfactory. **b)** That concert slapped, no cap. **c)** The concert was groovy.
2. An email to your manager about a new process: **a)** The new process is lowkey iconic. **b)** The new process is working well; it has saved us about an hour a day. **c)** The new process is da bomb.
3. A friendly team chat after a long day: **a)** Totally wiped out, heading home. **b)** I am experiencing considerable fatigue. **c)** I'm knackered, innit, mate. (You live in Chicago and have never lived in Britain.)
4. A report on customer feedback: **a)** Customers were gutted about the delay. **b)** Customers were deeply disappointed by the delay. **c)** Customers got the ick from the delay.

Now explain in one sentence why option c) in item 3 is risky: _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 4: ALLUSIONS

Complete each sentence with an allusion from the box, then write what it means here.

Achilles' heel · a Trojan horse · Groundhog Day · Catch-22 · met his Waterloo · the Midas touch

1. The free app turned out to be _____: it quietly collected all our data. Meaning: _____
2. Every day on the night shift felt like _____. Meaning: _____
3. She's a brilliant speaker, but numbers are her _____. Meaning: _____
4. You need experience to get the job and the job to get experience: a real _____. Meaning: _____
5. Every café she opens is a success; she has _____. Meaning: _____
6. The undefeated chess champion finally _____ against a twelve-year-old. Meaning: _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 5: HEAR IT FAST, WRITE IT FULL

Write the full form.

1. Whatcha gonna do? _____
2. Didja see the game? _____
3. Lemme know if ya need anything. _____
4. I dunno, I kinda wanna stay in. _____
5. You shoulda told me. _____

6. We gotta go. _____

7. Wouldja mind closing the door? _____

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: ASKING ABOUT A REFERENCE

Keiko: So the new booking system goes live on Monday.

Marc: Houston, we have a problem: nobody's been trained on it.

Keiko: Sorry, is that a reference to something? Everyone laughed, and I think I missed the joke.

Marc: Oh, fair question. It's from the Apollo 13 mission, via the film. People say it when something's gone wrong, usually with a straight face.

Keiko: Got it. So it's deadpan: a calm line for a serious problem.

Marc: Exactly. Though, to be fair, "nobody's been trained" is less Apollo 13 and more Groundhog Day. We have this problem every single launch.

Keiko: That one I know: the film where the same day repeats. Right, let's schedule the training before it becomes a Catch-22.

Marc: Now you're just showing off.

Underline the three allusions. How does Keiko ask about the reference without losing face? Is Marc's last line an insult or a compliment? How do you know?

◆ GROUP WORK – MEDIA DECODING LAB

Visit four stations, four minutes each. At every station, leave one **gloss for a newcomer**: one or two sentences that someone new to the culture could understand.

Station 1 • Headlines	
Station 2 • Memes in words	
Station 3 • Allusion hunt	
Station 4 • Slang & register	

"Gloss it for a newcomer" check: ☐ accurate • ☐ understandable without the cultural background • ☐ respectful to the community the word or reference comes from

◆ SAY – SELF-CHECK: CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

As everything goes wrong, a character says flatly, "Well, this is going great." What is actually meant?

- A) Things are genuinely going well.
- B) The speaker has no opinion either way.
- C) The opposite: things are going badly (sarcasm).

2

You're watching a comedy and a line gets a big laugh, but you didn't understand it. What's the best response?

- A) Pause and refuse to continue until you fully understand that one joke.
- B) Note that a reference probably passed, keep following the gist, and look it up later.
- C) Conclude that your English isn't good enough for real media.

3

You're emailing your manager to say the new schedule is working well. Which sentence is best?

- A) "No cap, the new schedule slaps."
- B) "The new schedule is working really well for the team."
- C) "The new schedule is lowkey iconic."

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ place slang by register and currency, and choose plain English when in doubt
- ◆ ☐ notice when a reference is doing invisible work, and decode common allusions
- ◆ ☐ decode headlines and memes described in words, including puns
- ◆ ☐ hear the reductions of fast speech and catch the load-bearing words
- ◆ ☐ read sarcasm from the tone and the situation, not the dictionary

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Think of a film, show or podcast that once felt impossible to follow. What made it hard, and what has changed?

◆ MODULE 5 – LOOK BACK AT MY GOAL

My goal after Progress Test 1 was: _____

Did I practice it? What happened? _____

My next step: _____

Writing with Authority

Three workshops on the difference between prose that is correct and prose that is trusted. Write for a reader who owes you nothing and can leave at any line; build a long piece whose architecture carries that reader across thousands of words; and polish the surface until nothing snags a careful eye.

Lessons 6.1–6.3

Classes C17–C19

Level C2

Name: _____

HOW THIS MODULE WORKS

Each task is labeled **Read, Listen, Write, Say** or **Pair work**. Nearly every writing task has many good answers; judge yours by its effect on a reader, not by whether it matches a model.

You decide what to share. Any anecdote may be real, invented, or borrowed from a writer identity card, and every argument task comes with an assigned side: you are practicing a craft, not declaring a belief. Drafts are read by one or two classmates only, and nothing you write is shown to the class without your permission.

◆ READ AND SAY — NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

an op-ed	a hook	the line	throat-clearing
a concession	to rebut	an anecdote	a landing (the close)
a verdict	to calibrate	grounded	a spoiler
front-loading	a standfirst	clickbait	voice
a commission	a pitch		

the line = the single thing an op-ed argues, sayable in one breath · **throat-clearing** = an opening that announces a subject instead of engaging the reader · **to calibrate** = to adjust a judgment precisely, neither inflated nor deflated · **a standfirst** = the one-sentence summary printed under a headline

◆ GRAMMAR BOX — THE GENRE TOOLKIT

The contract has changed. An examiner is paid to read every word; your reader is free to leave at any line. Every sentence must earn the next.

Op-ed arc	hook → the line → the strongest objection, granted → rebuttal (one statistic, one story) → a close that lands, often echoing the hook
Review arc	description (minimal, no spoilers) → evaluation (every judgment anchored to a detail) → a calibrated verdict the reader can act on
Feature arc	a specific headline and standfirst → the payoff early → one idea per paragraph → subheadings → written to one reader
Concede → turn	It's tempting to think..., but · The obvious reply is that... · None of this is to deny that...; it is to insist that...
Reframe	The real question is not X but Y. · Here is what we too often forget: ... · If that sounds alarmist, consider...
Evaluate	What makes X remarkable is... · Where it falls short is... · It never quite earns its... · The result is more X than Y.
Verdict	For all its flaws, ... · worth the trip for ... alone · a must-read · where lesser work would..., this...

Delete on sight: *In today's fast-paced world... · This article will discuss... · It is important to note that... · In conclusion, ...*

◆ LISTEN – EXERCISE 1: THE EDITOR'S CALL

An editor calls a writer about a draft restaurant review. Will it be published? What five changes does the editor ask for?

Published? _____

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

5. _____

Which change would improve your own writing most? _____

◆ READ – EXERCISE 2: ANATOMY OF AN OP-ED

Read the opinion piece. In the margin, label the seven moves: **hook** · **line** · **concession** · **rebuttal** · **evidence** · **anecdote** · **close**.

GIVE US BACK THE LUNCH HOUR

(1) At 12:47 last Tuesday I ate a cheese sandwich over my keyboard while answering an email about a meeting about lunch. (2) I suspect you have done something similar this week, and I want to suggest that it is making us worse at our jobs. (3) The desk lunch is not a sign of dedication; it is a false economy, and it is time offices treated the lunch hour as part of the working day rather than a gap in it.

(4) The obvious reply is that busy people are simply busy: the work has to be done, and an hour away from it is an hour lost. (5) That is true, and it is exactly the problem. (6) In one office survey, more than half of employees said they rarely took a full break, yet the same employees rated the afternoon as their least productive time of day. (7) A colleague of mine, a data analyst, started walking to the river every day at one o'clock; within a month she was solving in ten minutes the problems that used to take her the whole afternoon. (8) Rest, it turns out, is not the opposite of work. It is part of how work gets done. (9) So take the hour. Leave the building. And next Tuesday at 12:47, let the email about lunch wait until after lunch.

Model text written for this course; the survey is invented for practice.

Write the piece's line in one sentence: _____

How does the close echo the hook? _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 3: HOOK CLINIC

Each opening is correct but inert. Rewrite it with the type of hook in brackets. Make the second sentence unavoidable.

1. (a vivid particular) "This review will evaluate the new food hall that opened downtown last month."

→ _____

2. (a counter-intuitive claim) "Smartwatches have many advantages and disadvantages for users."

→ _____

3. (an anecdote, real or invented) "Art museums are important cultural institutions in our cities."

→ _____

4. (a provocation) "The four-day working week is a topic that many companies are discussing nowadays."

→ _____

◆ WRITE — EXERCISE 4: CALIBRATE THE VERDICT

Each review sentence has one of five problems: **press release** (unrelieved praise), **grudge** (unrelieved scorn), **ungrounded** (no detail), **spoiler**, or **mush** (no verdict). Name the problem, then rewrite the sentence with authority.

1. "The album is absolutely perfect in every single way and everyone should buy it immediately." Problem:

→ _____

2. "The food was amazing and the vibe was great." Problem: _____

→ _____

3. "In the last chapter the narrator turns out to have invented the whole story, which is brilliant." Problem:

→ _____

4. "The phone has some good points and some bad points, so it depends on what you want." Problem:

→ _____

5. "The exhibition is a pointless waste of everyone's time and money." Problem: _____

→ _____

◆ READ — EXERCISE 5: MATCH THE PUBLICATION

The same idea, written for four outlets. Match each version to its publication: **a** serious broadsheet · **b** lifestyle blog · **c** HR trade magazine · **d** satirical column.

1. _____ "Retention data from mid-sized firms suggest that protected lunch breaks correlate with lower afternoon absenteeism; managers should consider formalizing them."

2. _____ "Okay, confession: I haven't eaten lunch away from my laptop since March. This week I tried something radical. I went outside."

3. _____ "The desk lunch has become a quiet marker of seriousness, and like most such markers, it measures anxiety rather than output."
4. _____ "Scientists confirm that the sandwich, when eaten over a keyboard, contains zero calories and one hundred percent regret."

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: THE VOICE IS WRONG

Editor: I like the argument, but the voice is all wrong for us. Who did you picture reading this?

Writer: Honestly? My old professor. I think I was still writing an essay.

Editor: That's the tell. Our reader is on a train, half-distracted, deciding by the second paragraph whether to bother.

Writer: So I cut "It is important to note that" and open on the bench by the river?

Editor: Exactly. And your verdict is hiding in paragraph four. Bring it up.

Writer: Less "one might argue," more "here's what nobody says out loud"?

Editor: Same rigor, human temperature. And keep the joke about the pigeons; it's the only line I read twice.

Pair work: read it twice, then swap roles. What are the editor's three instructions? Which one is about structure, which about voice, which about effect?

◆ PAIR WORK – WRITE-CRITIQUE-REVISE LAB

Pitch. Your Commission card names the outlet, the reader, the genre and the topic. Pitch your piece to the editor in three sentences: the hook, the line or verdict, and why this reader will care.

Outlet: _____ Reader: _____

My line / verdict in one breath: _____

Draft. 200–250 words now; finish to 250–350 at home.

Critique. Your reader marks the line where their attention dipped, then scores each criterion from 1 (not yet) to 4 (publishable).

Hook: makes the second sentence unavoidable	1 2 3 4
Line or verdict: one clear claim, findable early	1 2 3 4
Grounding: evidence, a story, a quotable detail	1 2 3 4
Voice: fits the outlet; a real person on the page	1 2 3 4
Close: lands rather than summarizes	1 2 3 4
Precision: the exact word; no throat-clearing	1 2 3 4
One strength (quote it)	
One suggestion (quote it)	

Revise. Rewrite three things only: the hook, the close, and the paragraph where your reader stopped.

◆ SAY — SELF-CHECK: CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

What is the single defining job of an op-ed's opening hook?

- A) To state the topic and thesis plainly up front
- B) To make the second sentence unavoidable
- C) To summarize everything the piece will cover

2

Which move most signals a trustworthy reviewer?

- A) Anchoring each verdict to a specific detail, and noting a flaw even in a rave
- B) Praising the work warmly from start to finish with no reservations
- C) Retelling the plot thoroughly and in order

3

Which closing verdict for a restaurant review is both calibrated and actionable?

A) "Overall, Ember has some strengths and some weaknesses, so readers should decide for themselves."

B) "Ember is, without doubt, the finest restaurant this city has ever seen."

C) "Go for the flatbread, forgive the service, skip the desserts: for all its flaws, Ember is the most interesting new kitchen downtown."

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ open with a hook that earns the next sentence, and delete throat-clearing
- ◆ ☐ state an op-ed's line in one breath, grant the strongest objection and rebut it
- ◆ ☐ write a review whose verdict is grounded in detail and calibrated, with no spoilers
- ◆ ☐ match headline, structure and voice to a named publication and its reader
- ◆ ☐ critique a peer's draft by its effect on a reader, and revise my own from critique

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Copy one hook you admire from real writing. In two sentences, say what move it makes and why a reader who owed it nothing kept reading.

◆ READ AND SAY — NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

a through-line	an argued outline	a reverse outline	a seam
to signpost	to paraphrase	patchwriting	an attribution verb
stance	a literature review	to synthesize	a research gap
terminological drift	an abstract	an executive summary	to contend
to concede	to draw on		

a through-line = the single controlling claim every section serves · **a seam** = the join between two sections · **patchwriting** = "paraphrase" that keeps the source's structure and swaps a few words: a form of plagiarism · **terminological drift** = one concept acquiring several names across a long text

◆ GRAMMAR BOX — ARCHITECTURE AND SOURCES

An outline is an argument in miniature. Give every section a one-line claim, not a topic. Then read the claims in order: if you could reorder them without loss, you have a list, not an argument.

Backward signpost	As noted in the previous section, ... · Having established that..., we now turn to...
Forward signpost	This section argues that... · The following section turns to... · This point is developed further in Section 4.
Locational signpost	The remainder of this report is organized as follows: ... · At this point it is worth stepping back...

The attribution verb carries your stance.

you accept it	demonstrates · shows · establishes
a defended position	argues · contends · maintains
you keep your distance	claims · asserts · alleges
an admission	concedes · acknowledges · grants
tentative	suggests · proposes · speculates
extends earlier work	draws on · builds on

neutral fact	notes · observes · points out
--------------	-------------------------------

Synthesize; don't list. A literature review shows how sources relate and where the gap lies.

Consensus	There is broad agreement that... · A growing body of work suggests... · Most studies concur that...
Divergence	Whereas A reports..., B finds... · Studies diverge, however, on...
Building on	Building on A's framework, B... · B extends this finding to...
The gap	Little attention has been paid to... · What remains unclear is whether...
Positioning	This report therefore asks... · The present study addresses...

Tense. A source's argument: present (*Rossi argues*). A specific study's result: past (*Rossi's 2021 study found*). A body of research: present perfect (*several studies have shown*).

◆ LISTEN – EXERCISE 1: THE SUPERVISION MEETING

A supervisor discusses a student's draft chapter. Is the supervisor happy with the sentences? With the structure? Note the three problems and the three fixes.

Problem	Fix
1. _____	_____
2. _____	_____
3. _____	_____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 2: CHOOSE THE ATTRIBUTION VERB

Complete each sentence with a verb whose stance fits the note in brackets. Use a different verb each time.

1. (you accept it as shown) The trial data _____ a clear effect on recall.
2. (skeptical distance) The company's brochure _____ that the app doubles productivity.
3. (an admission against interest) Even Garcia, a strong advocate, _____ that her sample was small.
4. (tentative) The paper cautiously _____ a link between noise and fatigue.
5. (extends earlier work) Nwosu's model _____ on Garcia's earlier framework.
6. (a defended position) Chen _____ that libraries are losing their core purpose.
7. (a neutral, accepted fact) Rossi _____ that most participants were under thirty.

◆ READ – EXERCISE 3: FROM TOPICS TO CLAIMS

Through-line: *Public libraries are becoming community hubs, but unless the hub feeds the loan desk, the reinvention will save the building and lose the reading.* Put the section claims in the order that makes the argument necessary (1–6).

_____ a. The evidence shows visits rising sharply wherever libraries added classes, makerspaces and meeting rooms.

_____ b. The debate is stuck on a false choice between "books" and "community"; the real variable is the link between them.

_____ c. The link can be designed: libraries that route every event past the shelves see loans recover.

_____ d. Yet loans keep falling, which suggests the new visitors rarely become readers.

_____ e. The question for library boards is therefore not whether to become a hub, but how to wire the hub to the books.

_____ f. The objection, granted: a hub is a fair use of public money even if nobody borrows a book.

Now replace three generic headings with informative ones for this piece.

"Background" → _____

"Discussion" → _____

"Conclusion" → _____

◆ READ – EXERCISE 4: PARAPHRASE, QUOTATION OR PATCHWRITING?

Original (Rossi, 2021, p. 14): "Background music with lyrics significantly impaired performance on reading tasks, whereas instrumental music had no measurable effect."

Label each version: **P** acceptable paraphrase · **Q** correct quotation · **PW** patchwriting · **U** uncited idea.

1. _____ Background songs with words considerably damaged performance in reading activities, while instrumental music had no noticeable effect (Rossi, 2021).

2. _____ Rossi (2021) found that lyrics, not music as such, seem to get in the way of reading: instrumental tracks made no measurable difference.

3. _____ Music with lyrics, it turns out, makes reading harder, while instrumental music does not.

4. _____ Rossi (2021) reports that music with lyrics "significantly impaired performance on reading tasks" (p. 14).

Rewrite version 1 as a genuine paraphrase with a stance verb: _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 5: SHOPPING LIST INTO SYNTHESIS

This "literature review" lists sources one by one. Rewrite it as one synthesized paragraph (about 90 words) that shows consensus, divergence and the gap. Keep every finding and every citation.

Garcia (2020) studied twelve city libraries. She found that visits rose by 40% after they added classes and meeting rooms. Nwosu (2022) studied libraries in smaller towns. He also found that visits rose. Chen (2023) looked at borrowing data. She found that loans continued to fall. Nobody has studied whether the new visitors borrow books.

Sources invented for practice.

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: PAGE NINE

Supervisor: Your chapter is well written line by line, but I got lost around page nine. Where's the reader supposed to be by then?

Student: I think I stopped signposting. I knew where I was, so I assumed the reader did.

Supervisor: That's the classic long-form trap. You can hold the whole in your head; your reader can't.

Student: So a "Having established X, this section turns to Y" at each seam?

Supervisor: Exactly. And your review of the literature reads like a queue: Smith found, Lee found, Park found. Tell me where they agree, where they part company, and what nobody has asked yet.

Student: And the gap is where my chapter comes in.

Supervisor: Now you're writing an argument, not a bibliography.

Pair work: read it twice. Which two problems does the supervisor name? Which signpost does the student offer?

◆ PAIR WORK – ARCHITECTURE LAB

Plan a piece of 1,500–2,500 words on your Source Pack's question (or a question from your own field).

Through-line (a claim someone could disagree with): _____

Informative heading	One-line claim	Sources · verb	Words
1.			
2.			
3.			

4.			
5.			
6.			
7.			

Supervision. Your partner reads your claims aloud in order. Could any two sections swap? Is the through-line contestable? Where is the strongest objection? Which key term will you hold constant?

Draft one section (250–300 words).

☐ a backward and a forward signpost at the start · ☐ at least two sources synthesized · ☐ three different attribution verbs, chosen for stance · ☐ at least one paraphrase, at most one short quotation · ☐ one key term held constant · ☐ ends by pointing forward

Reverse-outline check. Your partner writes one sentence per paragraph: what does it *do*?

◆ SAY — SELF-CHECK: CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

What is the surest test that an outline is a genuine argument rather than a list?

- A) It has enough sections to fill the word count
- B) Every section is labeled with a neutral category heading
- C) You could not reorder the sections without breaking the argument

2

When should you write the abstract, and what should it do?

- A) First, as a promise of what the piece will cover
- B) Last, but withholding the findings to make the reader read on
- C) Last, and it should summarize the whole, delivering the actual findings

3

Which sentence synthesizes sources rather than listing them?

- A) "Garcia (2020) studied visits. Chen (2023) studied loans. Both are interesting."
- B) "Whereas Garcia (2020) reports a sharp rise in library visits, Chen (2023) finds that loans continue to fall; what remains unclear is whether new visitors ever borrow books."
- C) "According to Garcia (2020), she says that visits rose, and according to Chen (2023), she says that loans fell."

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ write a contestable through-line and an outline whose claims form a necessary sequence
- ◆ ☐ write informative headings a skimming reader could reconstruct the argument from
- ◆ ☐ signpost backward, forward and locationally at every seam
- ◆ ☐ paraphrase without patchwriting, and choose attribution verbs for stance
- ◆ ☐ synthesize sources by consensus, divergence and gap, and hold one term per concept

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Think of a long piece you have read recently. Does it have a real through-line, or is it an "and also" list?

Where did it lose you, if anywhere?

◆ READ AND SAY – NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

a restrictive clause	a non-restrictive clause	a comma splice	a dangling modifier
a misplaced modifier	parallelism	the serial (Oxford) comma	an em dash
an en dash	an aside	the subjunctive	hypercorrection
a convention	a myth	house style	a style sheet
to proofread	a false alarm		

a **comma splice** = two independent clauses joined by a comma alone · a **dangling modifier** = an opening phrase with no proper subject to attach to · **hypercorrection** = an error made by trying too hard to be correct ("between you and I") · **house style** = a publication's chosen set of conventions

◆ GRAMMAR BOX – MARKS, TESTS AND CONVENTIONS

Semicolon ;	joins two closely linked independent clauses · separates list items that contain commas	The café was full; the bakery next door was empty.
Colon :	after a complete clause, delivers what it promised	The menu has one weakness: dessert.
Em dash —	an emphatic aside or a sudden turn; use sparingly	They had planned for everything — and then the power failed.
Three volumes	commas (neutral) · dashes (loud) · parentheses (quiet)	The proposal (after much debate) was approved.
Restrictive	identifies which one: <i>that / who</i> , no commas	The report that I sent yesterday is final.
Non-restrictive	adds information: <i>, which / , who</i> , with commas	The report, which I sent yesterday, is final.
who / whom	answer with <i>he</i> or <i>him</i> ; <i>him</i> → <i>whom</i> (always after a preposition in formal writing)	
you and me	drop the other person: <i>between me and the wall</i> → <i>between you and me</i>	

fewer / less	can you count it? <i>fewer errors</i> · <i>less traffic</i> (but <i>less than five miles</i>)
danglers	whose action is it? The opening phrase must fit the subject.
only · almost · even	place right before what they limit: <i>We sell only organic eggs.</i>
parallelism	same form in a series and after <i>not only... but also, either... or</i>
subjunctive	<i>If I were you</i> · <i>I insist that he be present</i>

Rule, convention or myth? Rules protect meaning (danglers, restrictive commas, the comma splice). Conventions signal register (*whom*, the subjunctive *were*). Myths may be ignored: you may split an infinitive, end a sentence with a preposition, and begin one with *And* or *But*.

	American	British
Quotation marks	"double," with commas and periods inside	'single' is common; punctuation inside only if it belongs to the quotation
Dash	em dash, closed in book style (word—word), often spaced in journalism	spaced en dash (word – word)
Oxford comma	standard in most style guides	optional; many newspapers omit it
Collective nouns	The team is winning.	The team is / are winning.
Titles	Mr. · Dr.	Mr · Dr
End mark	period	full stop

Whichever you choose, choose once: consistency is the professional rule.

◆ LISTEN – EXERCISE 1: HEAR THE PUNCTUATION

Your teacher reads six sentences. Listen to the pauses and the pitch, then add the punctuation you hear.

1. The proposal after much debate was approved
2. The café was full the bakery next door was empty
3. She had one goal to win
4. They had planned for everything and then the power failed
5. My colleague who speaks four languages translated the menu
6. We visited Lisbon Portugal Accra Ghana and Hanoi Vietnam

◆ READ – EXERCISE 2: ONE OR SEVERAL?

Answer each question in a few words.

1. "The employees who worked overtime received a bonus." Did every employee receive a bonus?

2. "The employees, who worked overtime, received a bonus." Did every employee receive a bonus?

3. "The laptops that were left in the office were stolen." Were all the laptops stolen?

4. "I'd like to thank my parents, the head chef and the night porter." How many people might the writer be thanking? How would you remove the doubt? _____

5. "Our new app, which launched on Monday, has 10,000 users." How many new apps does the company have? _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 3: CHOOSE THE MARK

Punctuate each sentence for the effect described. Use ; : – () ,

1. (two balanced clauses, no conjunction) The reviews were glowing the bookings were not

2. (deliver the punchline) The new policy has one flaw nobody asked the staff _____

3. (a loud aside) The launch after three delays and one lawsuit went smoothly _____

4. (a quiet aside) The launch after three delays went smoothly _____

5. (fix the comma splice two ways) It rained all morning, we canceled the tour.

→ _____

→ _____

6. (a list with internal commas) Our speakers are Ana Ruiz, a chef Tom Park, a designer and Lin Wei, an architect _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 4: DANGLERS, STRAY MODIFIERS AND PARALLELISM

Each sentence says something the writer did not mean, or lurches. Rewrite it.

1. Rushing to catch the train, my coffee spilled everywhere.

→ _____

2. Having finished the report, the printer jammed.

→ _____

3. We almost drove 500 miles that day. (We did drive; it was nearly 500.)

→ _____

4. The manual explains how to install, configuring, and the maintenance of the device.

→ _____

5. The role calls for someone who is diligent, with creativity, and can lead a team.

→ _____

6. To succeed you must be not only skilled but also you need discipline.

→ _____

◆ READ – EXERCISE 5: RULE, CONVENTION, MYTH, OR HOUSE STYLE?

Label each statement **R** (rule: breaking it changes or obscures meaning), **C** (convention of formal register), **M** (myth), or **H** (US/UK house style: pick one and hold it).

1. _____ Never split an infinitive.
2. _____ An introductory participle must attach to the subject of the main clause.
3. _____ Use *whom* after a preposition in formal writing.
4. _____ Put the comma inside the closing quotation mark.
5. _____ Never begin a sentence with *But*.
6. _____ Non-restrictive clauses take commas; restrictive ones don't.
7. _____ Write *If I were you*, not *If I was you*.
8. _____ Spell it *organize*, not *organise*.

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: IT READS FLAT

Editor: The argument's fine, but it reads flat. Every sentence is the same length.

Writer: They're all grammatically correct, though.

Editor: Correct isn't the same as alive. Join those two short ones with a semicolon; they're one thought. Then let a short sentence land after your long one.

Writer: And the dash in paragraph two?

Editor: Keep it. It's the only one on the page, which is why it works. The five in paragraph four, though...

Writer: So the marks aren't just about avoiding errors; they're how the sentence moves.

Editor: Now you're hearing it. The rules keep you correct; the rhythm keeps you read.

Pair work: read it aloud, letting each mark shape your pause. Which three changes does the editor ask for?

◆ PAIR WORK – STYLE SHEET AND EDITING RACE

Style sheet. With your partner, agree a five-line house style for a book: quotation marks, dashes, the Oxford comma, spelling, collective nouns.

1. _____ 2. _____
3. _____ 4. _____

5. _____

Editing Race. Four stations, eight faults each, four minutes per station. Fix each fault **and name the point**.
Leave the myths alone.

Station	Fixes (+1)	Names (+1)	False alarms (-1)	Style bonus (+2)	Total
1 · Café review					
2 · Research paragraph					
3 · Night-bus feature					
4 · Office memo					

My personal watch list (the two or three fine points I will proofread for in every piece):

◆ SAY – SELF-CHECK: CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

"My sister, who lives in Madrid, is a lawyer." What does the pair of commas tell the reader?

- A) The writer has several sisters; the Madrid one is the lawyer
- B) The writer has one sister; that she lives in Madrid is extra information
- C) Nothing; the commas are optional and change nothing

2

Which "rule" is actually a myth a C2 writer may freely ignore?

- A) "Never end a sentence with a preposition"
- B) "An introductory participle must attach to the subject of the main clause"
- C) "Non-restrictive clauses take commas; restrictive ones don't"

3

Which sentence is free of faults?

A) "Having checked the figures twice, the report was approved by the analyst, the board, which met on Friday, agreed."

B) "Having checked the figures twice, the analyst approved the report, the board which met on Friday agreed."

C) "Having checked the figures twice, the analyst approved the report; the board, which met on Friday, agreed."

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ use the semicolon, colon and em dash for their jobs, and choose the volume of an aside
- ◆ ☐ explain how commas change the meaning of a relative clause, and use the Oxford comma to prevent a misreading
- ◆ ☐ repair dangling and misplaced modifiers and faulty parallelism
- ◆ ☐ tell a rule from a convention or a myth, and leave the myths alone
- ◆ ☐ apply one US or UK house style consistently and justify every correction by name

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Which fine point do you most often miss in your own writing? Which "rule" you were once taught can you now let go of?

Communicating Across Cultures

Three lessons on what fluent English cannot do by itself. Two people can share flawless grammar and still misread each other, because the unwritten rules for using the language differ. Here you learn to read those rules, to negotiate across them with tact, and to carry meaning, not merely words, from one language into another.

Lessons 7.1–7.3

Classes C20–C22

Level C2

Name: _____

HOW THIS MODULE WORKS

Each heading tells you what to do: **Read**, **Listen**, **Write**, **Say** or **With a partner**. Most tasks have several good answers; what matters is that your choice suits the person, the moment and the purpose, and that you can explain why.

This module is about **situations, not nationalities**. You will never be asked to explain "how people are" in any country, or to speak for a culture or a language community. When a task draws on your own experience, you decide what to share: your real life, **or** a new identity card, **or** something you invent. All three are equally good. In role-plays you play the card, not yourself, and you can always say "Pass." Using your other languages in Lesson 7.3 is welcome and entirely optional.

◆ READ AND SAY — NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

— meaning built from context and convention, not from the words alone pragmatics	— the person you are speaking with an interlocutor	— a person's dignity and public self-image; face	— a request, refusal or a word or phrase that reduces force (a face-threatening act a hedge / a softener
— to work out what a softened or indirect message really means to decode	— to wave it away modestly (to deflect a compliment	— a subject a community treats as off-limits or delicate taboo	— a gentler word for something delicate (a euphemism
— a disguised, mild substitute for a swear word (a minced oath	— (of a joke or remark) to produce the wrong effect; self-deprecation · banter · understatement · misfire	— (of a joke or remark) to produce the wrong effect; to understate · a irony	— kinds of humor that depend on a slight frame the humor

I don't suppose you could...?

Would there be any chance of...?

I see it slightly differently, though I may be missing something.

Please feel free not to answer.

When you said..., did you mean...?

Did I get the wrong idea?

That's on me.

No harm done.

◆ GRAMMAR BOX — THE GRAMMAR OF INDIRECTNESS

Negative + modal question

I don't suppose you **could** take another look at the figures?

Distancing (past, progressive, <i>would</i>)	I was wondering whether... · Would there be any chance of...? · Might it be possible to...?
Conditional cushion	If it's not too much trouble, could you...?
Concede, counter, leave the door open	I see where you're coming from, but... · ..., though I may be missing something.
Clarifying check	When you said "we'll see," did you mean it's unlikely? · Just so I don't assume, are you saying...?
Offering an exit	Please feel free not to answer. · Tell me if I'm straying into something you'd rather not discuss.

Four politeness strategies for a face-threatening act:

Bald on record	direct, unsoftened: urgency, close relationships, efficiency	Watch out, the step!
Positive politeness	builds closeness: <i>we</i> , <i>let's</i> , compliments, common ground	You're brilliant with spreadsheets. Can we look at this together?
Negative politeness	respects distance: hedges, apologies, options	Sorry to bother you. Would you mind if I moved your bag?
Off record	a hint the listener must infer (and can ignore)	Gosh, it's chilly in here.

Remember: an indirect refusal is still a refusal. *That would be quite challenging* and *I'll see what I can do* may be the whole answer, delivered in a form that saves face.

◆ LISTEN – EXERCISE 1: A MISUNDERSTANDING, REPAIRED

Your teacher reads a conversation between Maya and Jun, two colleagues meeting for the first time on a joint project. Answer the questions.

1. What did Jun actually mean by "That would be quite challenging"? _____
2. Which second phrase of Jun's did Maya also read as agreement? _____
3. What made Maya realize something had gone wrong? _____
4. Complete the repair phrases.

"Have I got the wrong _____ of the stick?" · "I may have just _____ over something." · "No, that's _____ me." · "Let me _____ up." · "We'll get the _____ of each other."

5. Which deadline do they agree on in the end, and why is it better? _____

◆ READ AND WRITE – EXERCISE 2: NAME THE STRATEGY

Label each utterance **BR** (bald on record), **PP** (positive politeness), **NP** (negative politeness) or **OR** (off record).

1. "Watch out, the step!" _____
2. "I don't suppose you could lend me your charger for ten minutes?" _____
3. "Hey, you're a genius with spreadsheets. Shall we tackle this one together?" _____
4. "Gosh, it's chilly in here." (The window is open.) _____
5. "Sorry to bother you. Would you mind terribly if I moved your bag?" _____
6. "Let's grab lunch and sort this out, just the two of us." _____
7. "Send me the file by three." _____
8. "I'd have thought someone might have mentioned the change to me." _____

Which two items could be perfectly polite in one setting and abrupt in another? Explain briefly.

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 3: DECODE THE HEDGE

For each reply to a request, write what it may really mean, then a clarifying check that does not accuse.

They said...	It may mean...	Your check
1. "That would be quite challenging."	_____	_____
2. "I'll see what I can do."	_____	_____
3. "It's an interesting idea."	_____	_____
4. "We'll have to see."	_____	_____
5. "Mm. Maybe next time."	_____	_____
6. (after a long pause) "Yes... I think that could work."	_____	_____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 4: TABOO AS LANGUAGE – THE EUPHEMISM LADDER

Every language fences off delicate subjects and invents gentler (and harsher) ways to name them. Put each set in order from **blunt or jokey** (dysphemism) to **neutral** to **gentle** (euphemism).

1. passed away · kicked the bucket · died → _____
2. was let go · got the boot · was fired → _____
3. the facilities · the john · the bathroom → _____
4. over the hill · senior · older → _____

5. being economical with the truth · lying through his teeth · not telling the truth → _____

6. budget-friendly · cheap · inexpensive → _____

Now answer: (a) Which word from set 1 belongs in a condolence card? _____ (b) What do *darn*, *gosh*, *heck* and *shoot* have in common? _____ (c) *Toilet* → *bathroom* → *restroom*: why do euphemisms keep being replaced? _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 5: WHEN HUMOR MISFIRES

Write a light repair for each situation: notice, clarify if needed, realign. Keep it short; don't explain the joke.

1. In a downpour you said "Lovely weather!" A new colleague looks puzzled: "But... it is raining?"

→ _____

2. You teased a colleague you met yesterday, "Late again? Must be nice!", and her smile vanished.

→ _____

3. You joked "Oh, I'm hopeless with numbers," and your manager has just reassigned the budget task to someone else.

→ _____

4. Your reference to a TV show met blank faces around the table.

→ _____

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: THE COMPLIMENT AND THE PAUSE

Lena: That was a terrific presentation, Arjun. The staffing chart really made the case.

Arjun: Oh, no, it was very rough. I rushed the second half.

Lena: Well, it didn't look rushed from where I was sitting. Can I ask you something about the budget slide?

Arjun: Of course.

Lena: Do you think the board will approve the extra hours?

Arjun: ...

Lena: Take your time. I know it's a tricky one.

Arjun: Thank you. Honestly, I think it will be difficult. It might be wise to prepare a smaller version.

Lena: So when you say "difficult," you'd expect a no as it stands?

Arjun: As it stands, yes, I think so.

Lena: Good to know. Let's draft the smaller version together, then.

Find: a deflected compliment and how Lena handles it; a silence handled well; a hedge that gets decoded; a clarifying check. Which strategy is "Let's draft it together"?

◆ WITH A PARTNER — CRITICAL-INCIDENT CLINIC

Your group receives an invented incident: two people, a setting, what was said and done. There is no villain. Work through the frame, then script a bridge.

Describe	Only the observable words and actions. No judgments about character.
Interpret	At least two good-faith readings for each person.
Evaluate	Which dimension was in play? directness · silence · compliment · small talk / taboo · humor. What was each person trying to do by their own rules?
Bridge	The exact words: ☐ a softener ☐ a clarifying check ☐ a realigning line ☐ responsibility taken, not assigned

Peer review: the good-faith test. Could both people in the incident read this analysis and feel fairly described?

One strength (quote it)	
One suggestion (quote it)	

◆ SAY — SELF-CHECK: CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

A colleague responds to your request with "That might be a little difficult." In many indirect-communication contexts, the safest reading is:

- A) They're just being shy; press for a firm yes.
- B) It may well be a polite "no": treat the hedge as the answer.
- C) It's basically a yes with a small caveat.

2

Which is the best first move when you sense a joke has landed wrong across a cultural gap?

- A) Carefully explain what made it funny until they get it.
- B) Say nothing and hope they didn't notice.
- C) Lightly acknowledge it ("Sorry, that was meant as a joke") and move on.

3

At a welcome lunch, a new colleague asks how much you earn. You'd rather not say. Which response is most graceful?

- A) "That's none of your business."
- B) (smiling) "Oh, enough to keep me in coffee! How are you finding the new office so far?"
- C) Tell them the exact figure, so as not to seem rude.

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ move a request, refusal or disagreement up or down the directness dial on purpose
- ◆ ☐ name a politeness strategy and explain why a speaker chose it
- ◆ ☐ decode a softener as content and check it without accusing
- ◆ ☐ discuss taboo as language: euphemism, dysphemism, minced oaths
- ◆ ☐ raise a sensitive topic with signal, soften, defer
- ◆ ☐ repair a misfire lightly: notice, clarify, realign

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Describe one moment when a pragmatic difference surfaced (real, invented, or from a new identity card) as a situation, not a stereotype. Then write the one line you would use now.

◆ READ AND SAY — NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

a position — what a side says it wants;	an interest — why it is BATNA your best alternative to a negotiated agreement	: what a you will walk-away if no deal is point reached — the least favorable deal you would still accept	a concession / to concede — gro you give
a package — a deal that settles several issues together	win-win — an outcome both sides can defend	to save face — to keep your dignity; a golden bridge	— a dignified way for the to depersonalize other side to change position — to move from "you vs me" to "us vs the problem"
a cushioned delivery — a hard message stated clearly, then softened around	assertive — calm, clear and firm; neither aggressive nor yielding	a holding phrase — words that buy a moment under pressure	weaponized courtesy — polite formulas used as a sneer

I appreciate where you're coming from, but...

I have one or two reservations.

We may have to agree to differ.

Ideally, we'd be looking at...

What matters most to you here?

If you were able to..., then we could...

Where might there be room to move?

Let me make sure I understand your concern.

◆ GRAMMAR BOX — CONDITIONALS FOR BARGAINING, FRAMING FOR FACE

Remote conditional trade	If you were able to commit to twelve months, (then) we could hold the rate. If you were to extend the deadline, we would absorb the extra scope.
Conditional connectors	We could move on price, provided (that) the timeline shifts. · as long as · on condition that Present simple after these: <i>provided you sign</i> , not <i>provided you will sign</i> .
Hypothetical proposals	What if we were to add Saturdays? · Supposing we added Saturdays, would you consider a longer term?
Downgraded verdict	That's a bad idea. → I have one or two reservations about that approach.
The situation as subject	The timing has been against us. · Things didn't quite go to plan. · I don't think either of us saw this coming.
Closing	Shall we say three percent, twelve months, rate frozen? · I'll put it in writing today.

The cushioned delivery: signpost (I'm afraid I have some disappointing news) → **state** it clearly and early → **explain** briefly and honestly → **look forward**. Softening is the wrapping, not the substance.

◆ LISTEN – EXERCISE 1: A DELICATE NEGOTIATION

A supplier, Rosa, and a client, Daniel, renegotiate a contract. Listen and answer.

1. Why does Rosa need to raise her price? _____
2. What is Daniel's opening position? _____
3. Complete the trade: "If you were able to _____ to a twelve-month term instead of six, then we _____ hold the rate much closer to where it is."
4. Without a longer term the rise would be _____ %; with it, _____ %.
5. What is Daniel's underlying interest, beyond the headline price? _____
6. What does Rosa offer to do today, and why does it help Daniel save face? _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 2: FROM BLUNT TO DIPLOMATIC

Rewrite each line diplomatically, using the word in brackets. Keep the message; change the temperature.

1. "You're wrong." (coming from) → _____
2. "That's a bad idea." (reservations) → _____
3. "No." (afraid) → _____
4. "We'll never agree." (differ) → _____
5. "You didn't deliver." (plan) → _____
6. "Your numbers are wrong." (correct me) → _____

◆ READ AND WRITE – EXERCISE 3: POSITIONS, INTERESTS AND BATNAS

Two teams both want the large meeting room on Thursday mornings. Label each statement **P** (position), **I** (interest) or **B** (BATNA).

1. "We need the big room every Thursday from nine to twelve." _____
2. "Our clients have to see the product demo on a large screen." _____
3. "If we can't agree, we'll book the hotel conference room across the street at \$150 a morning." _____
4. "The team has to meet face to face at least once a week before the client calls start." _____
5. "We won't give up Thursday." _____
6. "If this doesn't work out, we'll hold the weekly meeting online." _____
7. "Our designers need a wall they can sketch on together." _____
8. "Thursday mornings or nothing." _____

Now write one conditional trade that serves the interests of both teams.

→ _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 4: TURN A DEMAND INTO A TRADE

Rewrite each demand as a conditional offer, using the frame in brackets.

1. "Pay more or there's no deal." (If you were able to..., then we could...) → _____
2. "Pay the deposit now. We'll deliver early." (provided) → _____
3. "Order 500. We'll give you a discount." (as long as) → _____
4. "Extend the deadline." (Supposing we..., would you...?) → _____
5. "Sign for twelve months. We'll add weekend cover." (on condition that) → _____
6. "Lower the fee." (What if we were to...?) → _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 5: THE CUSHIONED MESSAGE

A. Put the four parts of this message in order (signpost → state → explain → look forward).

a) "The deciding factor was the schedule, not the quality of your work." · b) "I'm afraid I have some disappointing news, and I'd rather be straight with you." · c) "I'd be glad to talk through how to strengthen next year's application." · d) "The committee has decided not to fund the mural project this year."

Order: _____ → _____ → _____ → _____

B. This message is over-softened: the listener may not realize it is a no. Rewrite it so the decision is clear and early, and still kind.

So, we really loved so much about your proposal for the street festival, there were some wonderful ideas, and honestly it was such a close call, the whole committee was so impressed, and of course these things

are always so difficult, and budgets being what they are...

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: THE GOLDEN BRIDGE

Priya: I know you've put a great deal into the Friday launch, Marcus.

Marcus: And I'd still rather keep it. Moving it now would look as if we got it wrong.

Priya: I don't think anyone got it wrong. The supplier delays have been against us from the start.

Marcus: Maybe. But the board approved Friday.

Priya: With the new delivery figures in, it would be completely reasonable to revisit it. Your plan was sound given what we knew in March.

Marcus: Hmm. If we moved it, what would we actually gain?

Priya: A launch that works the first time. And if you were able to take the new date to the board, I could draft the explanation for you today.

Marcus: All right. Let's frame it as "phase one on Friday, full launch on the twentieth."

Priya: That's a story I'd be happy to stand behind.

Find: blaming the situation, crediting the other's reasoning, a golden bridge and a conditional trade. How does Marcus save face in the end?

◆ WITH A PARTNER – NEGOTIATION SIMULATION: PREP SHEET

You will receive a confidential brief. Keep your points table to yourself, and don't compare points with the other side: the tables measure different things.

Our opening position	_____
Our interests, ranked	1 _____ 2 _____ 3 _____
Our BATNA (and what it is worth)	_____
Our walk-away point	_____
Their likely interests	_____
Three conditional offers	If you were able to... _____ ...provided... _____

	What if we were to... _____
One face-saving line	_____
One holding phrase	_____

Deal sheet: record all five issues, or "We have agreed to differ."

Debrief: can you sell it upstairs? In one sentence, how will you present this deal to your board or members?

◆ SAY – SELF-CHECK: CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

Which phrase is the classic conditional trade at the heart of principled bargaining?

A) "If you were able to move the deadline, then we could look again at scope."

B) "Take it or leave it: that's my final offer."

C) "It'd be completely reasonable to revisit this now."

2

You must reject a strong proposal. What's the pitfall of over-softening the message?

A) It makes the message land too harshly.

B) It always makes the message too short.

C) The listener may not realize they were turned down and may feel misled later.

3

In negotiation, what is a BATNA?

A) Your ideal outcome, which you state in your opening position.

B) Your best alternative if no agreement is reached.

C) The first concession you make to show goodwill.

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ disagree and refuse without hostility: acknowledge, then counter
- ◆ ☐ tell a position from an interest, and know my BATNA and walk-away point
- ◆ ☐ make conditional trades (*If you were able to..., then we could... · provided that*)
- ◆ ☐ help the other side save face with a golden bridge
- ◆ ☐ deliver a difficult message clearly and early, then cushion it
- ◆ ☐ stay calm and assertive under pressure

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Recall a high-stakes conversation (real, invented, or from a new identity card). Rewrite one line of it from "you vs me" to "us vs the problem."

◆ READ AND SAY — NEW WORDS AND CHUNKS

to mediate / mediation	— to carry meaning between people the source language the target language who share a language or a frame	— the language you translate from into a false friend — a word that resembles one in another language but means something different	— a word with a shared origin and a similar meaning (a "true friend") a cognate
culture-bound	— tied to one community's experience; a gloss untranslatable — a short explanation of a word's meaning	without explanation of word equivalence literal ↔ idiomatic	— word for word ↔ natural for the target language — a rendering that keeps the content but loses the tone register loss
fidelity	— faithfulness to the original's meaning, register and tone	translation (written) interpretation (spoken)	— core principles of interpreting ethics confidentiality transparency impartiality

There isn't a single English word for it, but...

It literally means..., but what we'd actually say is...

The closest equivalent would be...

The nearest we get in English is..., though that loses...

Think of it as a kind of...

It's the word we use when...

Careful: it looks like..., but it really means...

Why word-for-word fails	idiom: <i>Je te tiens au courant</i> ≠ "I hold you in the current" → I'll keep you posted collocation: <i>make</i> a decision · <i>take</i> a photo · <i>make</i> a mistake grammar: "I have thirty years" → I'm thirty
The paraphrase pattern	signal the gap → give the literal image (if it helps) → state the plain meaning → paint the feeling or situation
Literal vs actual	It literally means "over the table," but what we'd actually say is "the talk after a meal."
Approximation with a cost	The nearest we get is "cozy," though that loses the social side.
The interpreter's voice	Professionals speak in the first person for the speaker: "I have two children" (not "She says she has two children"). They step out only to manage the talk, openly: "Interpreter speaking: may I check one word?"

The unit of translation is the idea, not the word. First ask what the text means and what it is doing; then find the natural way to do the same job in the target language.

◆ LISTEN – EXERCISE 1: *SOBREMESA*

Ana explains a word from her language to Tom. Map her explanation onto the paraphrase pattern.

1. The word: _____
2. The literal image: _____
3. The plain meaning: _____
4. The feeling behind it: _____
5. Tom's closest English equivalent: _____
6. What that equivalent loses: _____

◆ READ AND WRITE – EXERCISE 2: FALSE FRIENDS

Circle what each word really means.

1. Spanish *embarazada*: embarrassed / pregnant
2. French *actuellement*: actually / currently
3. German *Gift*: a present / poison
4. Italian *libreria*: library / bookstore
5. Portuguese *pretender*: to pretend / to intend
6. French *sensible*: sensible / sensitive
7. German *eventuell*: eventually / possibly
8. Russian *magazin*: a magazine / a shop
9. Japanese *manshon* (from "mansion"): a large luxurious house / an apartment building

Optional: add a false friend between two languages you know, or one that has tripped you up.

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 3: WHY WORD-FOR-WORD FAILS

Each sentence is a literal rendering. Label the mismatch **I** (idiom), **C** (collocation) or **G** (grammar), then write the natural English.

1. "I hold you in the current." _____ → _____
2. "Can you make a photo of us?" _____ → _____
3. "I have thirty-four years." _____ → _____
4. "She did a mistake in the report." _____ → _____
5. "Please open the light." _____ → _____
6. "Yesterday I have seen her at the station." _____ → _____
7. "He is very strong in cooking." _____ → _____
8. "Take your umbrella: it's raining ropes." _____ → _____

◆ WRITE – EXERCISE 4: PARAPHRASE THE IDIOM

For a listener who takes words literally, write the plain meaning of each English idiom. Add the image only if it helps.

1. to bite off more than you can chew → _____
2. the ball is in your court → _____
3. to cost an arm and a leg → _____
4. to be on the same page → _____
5. to kick the can down the road → _____
6. a blessing in disguise → _____

◆ READ AND WRITE – EXERCISE 5: REGISTER AND ETHICS

A. Register. A neighbor's handwritten note reads: *"Hey! Parcel came for you while you were out, so I grabbed it. Pop round whenever, I'm in all evening."* Which rendering keeps the tone?

- a) "Please be advised that a package addressed to you has been received and may be collected during evening hours." b) "Hi! A package came for you while you were out, so I took it in. Come by any time, I'm home all evening."

Answer: _____ Why is the other one a failure of fidelity even though the facts are right?

B. Ethics. Write T (true) or F (false).

1. An interpreter should leave out rude remarks to keep the peace. _____
2. Professional interpreters usually speak in the first person for the speaker. _____
3. If an interpreter doesn't catch a number, it's best to guess and keep the conversation moving.

4. What is said in an interpreted meeting stays confidential. _____
5. An interpreter may give advice if one side asks for it. _____
6. Children should not be asked to interpret in medical or legal appointments. _____

◆ READ AND SAY – DIALOGUE: INTERPRETING AT THE COMMUNITY CENTER

A volunteer interprets between a sports coordinator and a parent at a youth-soccer sign-up. The parent's words are shown in English; in reality the parent and the volunteer are speaking another language.

Coordinator: Registration closes on Friday. The fee is forty dollars, but we waive it for anyone who asks.

Volunteer: (to the parent, in the first person) Registration closes on Friday. The fee is forty dollars, but we waive it for anyone who asks.

Parent: I have two children. Can they be in the same group?

Volunteer: (to the coordinator) I have two children. Can they be in the same group?

Coordinator: It depends on their ages. The groups are U8 and U10.

Volunteer: Interpreter speaking: may I check a term? What does "U8" mean exactly?

Coordinator: Sure, it means "under eight": players who are seven or younger this season.

Volunteer: (to the parent) The interpreter asked what "U8" means; it means under eight. It depends on their ages. The groups are for under eight and under ten.

Parent: What would you do, if they were your kids?

Volunteer: I'm only here to interpret, so I'll pass that question to the coordinator, if you like.

Why does the volunteer say "I have two children," not "She says she has two children"? How does she handle the term she doesn't know? Why doesn't she answer "What would you do?"

◆ WITH A PARTNER – TRANSLATION & INTERPRETING LAB: RECORD

Part 1, ethics. For each dilemma card: the principle at stake and the interpreter's exact words.

Card ____	Principle: _____ · Words: _____
Card ____	Principle: _____ · Words: _____
Script 7.3-B	Breaches I noticed: _____

Part 2, mediate. Each round, the mediator chooses: (a) sight-translate a short, simple, public text in any language into natural English; (b) render a dense English notice into plain spoken English; or (c) convey an untranslatable word. The listener explains it back; the checker notes:

Round	Idea, not words?	Register kept?	Frame used (quote it)	Explained back: meaning + feeling?
1	☐	☐		☐ ☐
2	☐	☐		☐ ☐
3	☐	☐		☐ ☐

◆ SAY – SELF-CHECK: CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

Why does word-for-word translation of an idiom usually fail?

- A) Idioms are always too long to translate directly.
- B) An idiom's meaning isn't the sum of its words, so the literal version is opaque.
- C) The grammar can never be made correct.

2

What is the key difference between translation and interpreting?

- A) Translation is written, with time to craft; interpreting is live speech in real time.
- B) Translation is accurate and interpreting is deliberately loose.
- C) Interpreting needs no language skill, only speed.

3

A friend asks you to interpret at a meeting with her child's teacher. The teacher uses a word you don't know. What should you do?

- A) Guess from the context and keep going.
- B) Tell both people you need to check the word, then ask the teacher to explain it.
- C) Skip it; it's probably unimportant.

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ explain why word-for-word translation fails: idiom, collocation, grammar
- ◆ ☐ spot a false friend and warn someone about it
- ◆ ☐ convey an untranslatable word with the paraphrase pattern
- ◆ ☐ keep the register and tone of a text when I mediate it
- ◆ ☐ sight-translate or render a short text idea by idea
- ◆ ☐ name the core principles of interpreting ethics and use them in a dilemma

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Start your personal false-friend list with three entries (from your own languages, or from this lesson). Then write one sentence on how bringing a word into English differs from swapping it.

The Summit: Exams, Performance & Lifelong Command

Three arenas, one skill: showing the English you already command, at its best, when it counts. First the exam room, where mastery must be converted into marks. Then the stage, where meaning has to be made easy to receive. Finally a piece of your own choosing, presented and discussed among peers, and a plan for keeping your English growing long after the last lesson.

Lessons 8.1–8.3

Classes C23–C25

Level C2

Name: _____

HOW TASKS ARE LABELED

Each task says what kind of work it is: **Read · Listen · Write · Say · Pair work · Group work.**

When a task touches on your own life, you decide what to share: your real experience, a new identity card, or something invented are all equally valid, and you can always say "Pass." All practice items in 8.1 are original and written for this course; they imitate the style of proficiency-level exams but reproduce no real exam. For formats, timings and word limits, always consult the official provider's current specification.

◆ NEW WORDS — THE LANGUAGE OF THE EXAM ROOM

key word transformation : rewriting a sentence with the same meaning, using a given word you may not change	open cloze : a text with gaps and no options; mostly grammar words and fixed phrases	word formation : turning a given stem into the form the gap requires	gapped text : a passage from which sentences or paragraphs have been removed
a distractor : an option or a mention designed to attract a wrong answer	a breadcrumb : a reference word or connector that shows where a sentence belongs	band descriptors : the published criteria examiners mark against	task achievement : covering every part of what the prompt asks
an under-answered prompt : a response that ignores part of the task	the long turn : an extended solo answer in a speaking test	the collaborative task : a discussion with a partner that must reach a decision	to bank (the sure marks) : to secure the easy points first

◆ GRAMMAR BOX — THE KEY WORD TRANSFORMATION

The four checks. An answer scores only if all four are true.

Check	Question to ask	How marks are lost
-------	-----------------	--------------------

1 · Key word	Have I used the given word exactly as it is?	SOONER becomes <i>soon</i> ; NO disappears
2 · Word limit	Is my answer within the limit, counting the key word?	a contraction counts as two words
3 · Meaning	Does the new sentence mean exactly the same?	a detail added, softened or lost
4 · Fit	Is it grammatical with the words on both sides of the gap?	no inversion after a negative adverbial; a missing article

What the task likes to test

Negative inversion	No sooner had she arrived than... · On no account should you... · Not until the report came out did we... · Never before have I...
Fixed phrase + preposition	make sense of · make light of · on the brink of · in the wake of · cast doubt on · come in for criticism
Passive and causative	It is thought that he left → He is thought to have left · have the car serviced
Word formation	part of speech → negative prefix? (in-, un-, dis-, mis-, ir-) → plural or comparative? · persuade → persuasive · conclude → inconclusive

◆ STRATEGY BOX – TASK FAMILIES AT A GLANCE

Task family	What it really tests	Strategy
Open cloze · word formation · transformations · collocation choice	precision in grammar, lexis and collocation	bank the sure items fast; mark and return to the hard ones
Gapped text	cohesion across a whole text	the missing sentence must fit what comes before and after; follow the breadcrumbs
Multiple matching · inference	evidence-tracking	match on paraphrase, not repeated words; underline the proof
Essay summary	summarizing, evaluating, arguing in a set length	cover every part of the task; paraphrase, don't lift
Listening	gist · detail · attitude · inference	predict; listen for what the speaker settles on

Long turn · collaborative task	sustained, structured speech; genuine interaction	frame, signpost, close; invite, build, decide
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◆ EXERCISE 1 – KEY WORD TRANSFORMATIONS · WRITE

Complete the second sentence so that it means the same as the first, using the word given. Do not change the word. Use **between three and six words**, including the word given. Work under a light time limit: six minutes for all eight.

1. I couldn't understand the report at all. **NO**

I could make _____ the report.

2. As soon as he sat down, the phone rang. **SOONER**

No _____ than the phone rang.

3. You should never underestimate her. **ACCOUNT**

On _____ her.

4. I have never seen the sea before. **TIME**

This is _____ seen the sea.

5. The company very nearly collapsed last year. **BRINK**

Last year the company _____ collapse.

6. The director resigned soon after the scandal and because of it. **WAKE**

The director resigned _____ the scandal.

7. The committee did not take the complaint seriously. **LIGHT**

The committee _____ the complaint.

8. She only realized how serious the problem was when the report came out. **UNTIL**

Not _____ out did she realize how serious the problem was.

Which of the four checks do you most often fail? _____

◆ EXERCISE 2 – WORD FORMATION AND COLLOCATION · WRITE

A. Use the word in capitals to form a word that fits the gap. Decide the part of speech first, then check for a prefix.

1. Her argument was utterly _____. (PERSUADE)

2. The instructions were so _____ that no one knew what to do. (AMBIGUITY)

3. His _____ to commit was obvious to everyone in the room. (RELUCTANT)

4. The evidence was, regrettably, _____. (CONCLUDE)

5. Owing to _____ circumstances, tonight's concert has been canceled. (FORESEE)

6. The difference between the two sets of results was statistically _____. (SIGNIFY)

7. Whatever one thinks of her methods, her dedication is _____. (DISPUTE)

B. Circle the word that **collocates**. More than one may "mean" the right thing; only one keeps the right company.

1. There is a **strong** • heavy • thick • hard possibility that the talks will fail.
2. After the long journey, she fell into a **deep** • strong • thick • wide sleep.
3. The proposal came in for **scathing** • burning • piercing • sharpened criticism.
4. The new findings **cast** • put • made • placed doubt on the original theory.
5. It is an **open** • public • known • clear secret that the two directors dislike each other.

◆ EXERCISE 3 – GAPPED TEXT • READ

Three sentences have been removed from the text. Choose from A–D the sentence that fits each gap. There is one extra sentence. Then **underline the breadcrumb** in the text that proves each answer.

THE CURSE OF KNOWLEDGE

Anyone who has asked a brilliant colleague for directions and received a baffling answer has met what psychologists call the curse of knowledge. (1) _____. The expert has not become careless; the difficulty lies in the very thing that makes them expert.

Once we know something well, we lose access to the state of not knowing it. (2) _____. What was once a sequence of twelve deliberate steps has been compressed, through years of practice, into a single fluent gesture.

(3) _____. Asked to explain, the expert naturally describes the gesture rather than the steps, skipping precisely the moves a beginner most needs to see. The remedy, fortunately, is less mysterious than the problem: experts who watch a novice attempt the task, rather than simply describing it, quickly rediscover the steps they had forgotten they were taking.

- A. This compression is what allows a surgeon or a pianist to work at speed, but it comes at a price.
- B. Such answers are rarely the product of impatience.
- C. Knowledge does not merely accumulate; it reorganizes itself.
- D. Beginners, by contrast, tend to overestimate how much they have understood.

True, or true but not there? Write **S** (stated or clearly implied in the text) or **N** (it may be true, but the text doesn't say it).

1. Practice changes how knowledge is organized in an expert's mind. _____
2. Experts generally make poor teachers. _____
3. Watching a beginner can help an expert explain more clearly. _____

◆ EXERCISE 4 – THE ESSAY SUMMARY • READ • WRITE

A typical proficiency-style writing task: read the two texts, then write an essay that **summarizes and evaluates** the key points of both and gives **your own view**, in your own words, in about 240–280 words.

TEXT 1 • IN DEFENSE OF MEMORY

It has become fashionable to dismiss memorization as a relic of the schoolroom, made obsolete by the search engine. Yet this view misunderstands how thinking works. We can only reason with what we already hold in mind: a doctor who must look up every symptom cannot see a pattern, and a reader who must search for every reference cannot enjoy a poem. Far from competing with understanding, a well-stocked memory is its precondition. What we should abandon is not memorization but its duller methods.

TEXT 2 • THE SCARCE SKILL

Schools still devote hours to material that any student can retrieve in seconds. That time would be better spent teaching learners to judge sources, to connect ideas and to recognize what they do not know. Memory has not become worthless, but the premium has shifted: in a world of abundant information, the scarce skill is not recall but evaluation. A curriculum that rewards the student who remembers most, rather than the one who questions best, is preparing young people for a world that no longer exists.

Step 1. Identify two key points in each text and paraphrase them. Lifted phrases don't count.

	Key point (in your own words)
Text 1 • a	_____
Text 1 • b	_____
Text 2 • a	_____
Text 2 • b	_____

Step 2. Where do the texts agree, even partly? _____

Step 3. Plan four paragraphs: (1) the shared question and the two positions • (2) Text 1, summarized and evaluated • (3) Text 2, summarized and evaluated • (4) your own view, weighed. Does your plan cover every part of the task? ☐ summarize ☐ evaluate ☐ both texts ☐ my own view

Step 4 (at home). Write the essay in 40 minutes. Opening paragraph:

◆ EXERCISE 5 – THE STRATEGIST'S MOVE • LISTEN

A. What would a strategist do? Write one sentence for each.

1. In the Use of English paper, one gap has stumped you for two minutes. _____

2. A reading option "feels right," but you can't find words in the text to support it.

3. The writing prompt has two parts, and you have a brilliant idea for the first. _____

4. In the collaborative speaking task, your partner has fallen silent. _____

B. Listen past the distractor. Your teacher reads four short extracts. Each speaker mentions one thing first and then settles on another. Write what the speaker **settles on**, and one word for their attitude.

Extract	Question	The answer the speaker settles on	Attitude
1	What caused the delay?	_____	_____
2	How does the speaker feel about the new system?	_____	_____
3	Which supplier does she recommend, and why?	_____	_____
4	Why did she take up the cello?	_____	_____

◆ DIALOGUE – A COLLABORATIVE TASK, DONE WELL • READ • PAIR WORK

Examiner: Here are some ways a city could reduce traffic. Talk together about how effective each might be, and then decide which two to recommend.

Candidate A: Shall we start with congestion charging? On balance, I'd say it's effective but unpopular: it hits lower-income drivers hardest.

Candidate B: That's a fair point, though I'd add that the revenue can fund better public transportation, which softens the blow. What's your take on bike lanes?

Candidate A: I'm keen on them, cheap and healthy, but I see it slightly differently in that they only work where distances are short. So, are we agreed that charging plus investment in public transportation is our stronger pair?

Candidate B: Agreed. Let's recommend those two.

Label each move in the margin: **I** (invites the partner in) • **B** (builds on the partner's point) • **D** (differs, softly) • **C** (drives toward a conclusion). Which move comes last, and why must it? Why is nobody's turn longer than three sentences?

Read it in pairs, then do it again with a new task from your teacher, without the script.

◆ SPEAKING – THE SPEAKING CIRCUIT • GROUP WORK

Groups of three: **candidate, interlocutor, examiner**. **Round 1, the long turn**: choose one of two cards, prepare for one minute (three key words), speak for **two minutes**, answer one follow-up question. **Round 2, the collaborative task**: two candidates discuss the picture cards for three minutes and decide which two ideas to recommend; the third learner listens for interaction only. Rotate.

Rate yourself after your long turn, then compare with your examiner's report.

Criterion	My rating (Mastery · Secure · Developing)	One example, or one thing to change
Fluency & coherence: framed, signposted, closed		
Lexical range: precise, idiomatic, collocationally sound		
Grammatical range & accuracy		
Pronunciation: chunking, stress, intonation (not accent)		
Interaction (collaborative task): invited, built, decided		

◆ SELF-CHECK – CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

On the collaborative speaking task, what do examiners most reward?

A) One candidate delivering a fluent, uninterrupted speech

B) Genuine interaction: inviting, building, negotiating toward a decision

C) Reaching agreement as fast as possible with no discussion

2

A reading option seems true, but you can't find supporting words in the passage. You should:

A) choose it: it matches what you already know is true

B) leave it blank to be safe

C) reject it: if you can't underline the evidence, it isn't supported

3

Key word BRINK, 3–6 words. "The company very nearly collapsed." → "The company _____ collapse." Which answer scores?

A) was on the brink of

B) was on brink of

C) found itself teetering right on the brink of

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ explain why my lost marks are more likely to be technique than language
- ◆ ☐ check a key word transformation against all four checks before moving on
- ◆ ☐ choose the word that collocates, not merely the word that means the right thing
- ◆ ☐ place a missing sentence by its breadcrumbs, and reject an answer I cannot prove
- ◆ ☐ plan an essay summary that covers every part of the task
- ◆ ☐ give a framed, signposted long turn and invite a partner into a decision

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

Diagnose yourself as a test-taker: which task type most threatens your score, and is the threat one of language or of technique?

◆ NEW WORDS — THE LANGUAGE OF THE STAGE

a hook : an opening that earns attention in the first fifteen seconds

the spine : the signposted middle of a talk; its two or three points

a resonant close : an ending that resolves the talk and leaves one line behind

to fizzle out : to end weakly, trailing away instead of finishing

a beat : a short, deliberate pause

a breath group : a chunk of speech said on one breath, carrying one idea

contrastive stress : stress that picks out one word against its alternatives

vocal variety : changes of pace, pitch and volume that keep the ear awake

rapport : the sense of connection between a speaker and an audience

to read the room : to notice an audience's reactions and adjust

to field a question : to receive and answer a question, especially a difficult one

poise · composure : calm self-possession under pressure

to bridge back : to connect an answer to the talk's main thread

◆ GRAMMAR BOX — BUILDING A TALK FOR THE EAR

A reader can re-read; a listener cannot rewind. A talk must therefore be simpler and more audibly signposted than an essay: tell them what you'll tell them, tell them, then tell them what you told them.

Part	Its job	Language
The open	earn attention; open a curiosity gap	Every one of you made a decision this morning that you can't remember making. · Here's a number that surprised me: ... · Picture this: ...
The spine	carry two or three numbered points	I want to leave you with three thoughts, and here's the first. · Which brings me to my second point. · Now, and this is the part

		that matters, ...
The close	resolve; leave one line to carry out of the door	If you remember one thing today, let it be this. · And that brings me back to where we began. · So where does that leave us?

Rhetoric performed (the figures of Lesson 4.1, now said aloud)

Figure	Example	How to perform it
Tricolon (rule of three)	It was quick, it was clean, and it was completely wrong.	rise on one and two; let the third beat fall
Rhetorical question	And what did all that planning achieve? ... Nothing at all.	a falling tone, then a real silence before the answer
Antithesis	We have never known more and understood less.	stress both poles: MORE · LESS
Anaphora	Not in a year. Not in a decade. Not in a lifetime.	the same stress each time, rising energy

◆ GRAMMAR BOX — EMPHASIS AND Q&A

Emphasis	<i>wh</i> -cleft: What I want you to remember is this. · <i>it</i> -cleft: It's not talent that separates us; it's time. · fronting: This, I think, is the heart of it.
Acknowledge	That's a good question; let me take it in two parts. · I'm glad you raised that. · If I've understood your question correctly, ...
Concede and narrow	You're right about that; where I'd differ is... · That's a fair challenge, and you're absolutely right that...; what I'm arguing is narrower: ...
Admit a limit	I don't have that to hand, but here's how I'd find out. · That's outside what I've studied, but my honest guess is...
Bridge back	Let me come back to my main point here. · Which is exactly why... · Can I check I've answered what you were really asking?

◆ EXERCISE 1 — TECHNIQUE AND EFFECT · LISTEN · WRITE

A. Fill each gap with the technique that produces the effect. Choose from: *pause* · *rule of three* · *vocal variety* · *eye contact* · *rhetorical question* · *stress*. Use each once.

- To make a key line land and give the audience room to absorb it, use a deliberate _____ before and after it.
- To pull the audience into answering alongside you, ask a _____ and let it hang.
- To signal which single word carries the meaning of a sentence, place the _____ on that word.

4. To give a list a satisfying, complete feel, group the items as a _____.
5. To turn a room of strangers into a connected audience, hold friendly, individual _____.
6. To keep the ear awake and mark the start of a new section, use _____: a shift of pitch, pace and volume.

B. Your teacher reads "I never said she stole the money" five times, stressing a different word each time. Write the stressed word for each reading, then match it to its meaning (a–e).

Reading	Stressed word	Meaning
1	_____	_____
2	_____	_____
3	_____	_____
4	_____	_____
5	_____	_____

a) Someone else said it, not me. · b) A flat denial: it never happened. · c) I only implied it. · d) Someone else stole it. · e) She stole something else.

◆ EXERCISE 2 – COMPLETE THE DELIVERY PHRASE · WRITE

1. Opening a talk: "If you remember one _____ today, let it be this."
2. Acknowledging a hard question: "That's a good _____; let me take it in two parts."
3. Conceding, then narrowing: "You're right about that; where I'd _____ is here."
4. Closing by echoing the open: "And that brings me back to where we _____."
5. Dividing an answer: "Let me take that in two _____: the cost, and the timing."
6. Admitting a limit: "I don't have that to _____, but here's how I'd find out."

◆ EXERCISE 3 – OPEN, CLOSE, ANSWER · READ

Circle the strongest option in each set, and say why the others fall short.

- 1. Opening.** (a) "Um, so, I guess I'll start..." (b) "Every one of you made a decision this morning you can't remember making." (c) "Sorry, I'm a bit nervous and unprepared."
- 2. Closing.** (a) "So... yeah, that's about it." (b) "Anyway, I've probably gone on too long." (c) "Don't wait to be good before you begin. Begin."
- 3. A challenging question.** (a) "That's just wrong, actually." (b) "That's a fair challenge; you're right that starting lines differ. My point is narrower." (c) "I'd rather not get into that."

◆ EXERCISE 4 – MARK IT UP FOR DELIVERY · WRITE · SAY

Mark the passage for performance: | for a short pause, || for a long pause, and **underline** one stressed word in each breath group. The first line is done for you. Then read it aloud to a partner.

Every expert you admire || was once catastrophically bad | at the thing they're now famous for.

Every single one.

We tell ourselves a comforting lie: that talent is something you're handed at birth.

It lets us off the hook.

The gap between you and the person you admire is not talent. It is time.

Which line needs the longest pause before it? Why? _____

◆ EXERCISE 5 – FROM DEFENSIVE TO POISED • WRITE

Each answer is defensive, evasive or collapsing. Rewrite it so that it acknowledges, concedes what is fair, and narrows or bridges back.

1. Q: "Isn't a four-day week just a luxury for office workers?" A: "No, that's a ridiculous thing to say."

2. Q: "Where does your figure of 40% come from?" A: "Um, I don't remember. Maybe it's wrong. Sorry."

3. Q: "Doesn't this only work in big cities?" A: "I'd prefer not to talk about that."

Now write a poised answer to the hardest question anyone could ask about **your** speech:

◆ DIALOGUE – A SPEECH AND ITS Q&A • LISTEN • READ

Speaker: Every expert you admire was once catastrophically bad at the thing they're now famous for. [pause] Every single one.

Speaker: We tell ourselves a comforting lie: that talent is something you're handed at birth. It lets us off the hook. But I want to leave you with three thoughts, and here's the first: the people we call gifted are, almost always, just the people who refused to quit while they were still terrible.

Speaker: Think about that. [pause] The gap between you and the person you admire is not talent. It is time, and the willingness to be bad in public for longer than felt comfortable.

Speaker: So if you take one thing from this room today, let it be this: don't wait to be good before you begin. [pause] Begin, and let the being-good arrive on its own schedule.

Audience member: That's inspiring, but isn't it a bit easy to say? Some people really do start with more advantages than others.

Speaker: That's a fair challenge, and you're absolutely right: the starting lines are not equal, and I'd never pretend otherwise. What I'm arguing is narrower: that whatever your starting line, quitting early guarantees you stay behind it. Advantage helps. Persistence is the part that's yours to control. Does that distinction land for you?

Audience member: It does, actually. Thank you.

1. What "comforting lie" does the speaker name, and why does it "let us off the hook"?

2. Find an antithesis and the pauses that frame the key lines. What does each pause do?

3. Name the three moves in the answer to the challenge. Why is this more persuasive than arguing back?

Perform the speaker's lines in pairs: land every [pause], and stress one word per sentence.

◆ SPEAKING — THE SPEECH LAB • GROUP WORK

Groups of four: **speaker**, **timekeeper**, **questioner**, **feedback lead**. Speak for **three minutes**; answer one question; receive three feedback slips. Rotate.

My speech plan

Topic	_____
My open (in full)	_____ _____
Point 1 • signpost	_____
Point 2 • signpost	_____

(Point 3)	_____
One device, and where	☐ tricolon ☐ rhetorical question ☐ antithesis ☐ anaphora → _____
My close (in full)	_____ _____
Marked for delivery?	☐ three pauses ☐ three stressed words ☐ the last line slower
The question I fear	_____

What my listeners said

Slip	The line they remember	If this were theirs, they might...
1		
2		
3		

The one change I will make in my recording: _____

◆ SELF-CHECK – CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

Why is a deliberate pause before a key sentence so effective?

A) It primes the audience's attention and lets the line land

B) It simply slows the talk down to fill time

C) It hides the fact that the speaker is unprepared

2

A questioner challenges your talk. The most poised response is to:

A) concede the valid part, then narrow to your actual point

B) insist firmly that they're mistaken

C) decline to engage with the question

3

You are preparing a three-minute speech. The best way to prepare the words is to:

A) memorize every word so that nothing can go wrong

B) memorize the open and the close, and speak the middle from a skeleton of key points

C) improvise all of it, so that it sounds natural

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ open with a hook, signpost a spine, and close on a full stop
- ◆ ☐ perform a tricolon, a rhetorical question and an antithesis, not just write them
- ◆ ☐ use a deliberate pause and put the stress on the word that carries the meaning
- ◆ ☐ channel nerves with automatic bookends, a reframe and slow breathing
- ◆ ☐ field a hard question: acknowledge, concede, narrow, bridge back
- ◆ ☐ give a peer feedback that quotes before it judges

◆ MY NEW WORDS

◆ MY JOURNAL (2 SENTENCES)

What does stage fright feel like for you, and which one technique from today most helped you channel it rather than fight it?

YOUR PROJECT TIMELINE

End of C23: choose a format and a subject you genuinely have a view on. · **Before C24:** fill in the planning frame below (notes only). · **C24:** meet your salon group; say in one sentence what your piece will do. · **After C24:** draft, then polish until the seams disappear: **500–700 words**, or a **4–5 minute** speech. Send written pieces (or a five-line abstract of a speech) to your group by the evening before C25. Complete your lifelong-command plan. · **C25:** the Masterwork Salon. · **After C25:** hand in your piece, your plan and the self-check.

◆ NEW WORDS – THE LANGUAGE OF THE SUMMIT

a masterwork : a piece that shows the full range of a maker's skill	to orchestrate : to bring separate elements together into one performance	to hide the seams : to make deliberate craft feel effortless	a showreel : a display of techniques for their own sake, rather than a whole
a controlling idea : the single thought a piece is built to serve	to narrow a claim : to restate it in a more precise, more defensible form	a growth edge : the point where your next improvement lies	fossilization : an error that has become fixed despite advanced proficiency
accountability : a commitment someone else will ask you about	to inhabit a language : to live in it, not merely use it	to tend : to look after something so that it keeps growing	

◆ GRAMMAR BOX – THE FOUR FORMATS AND THE INTEGRATION MAP

Format	What you prepare	What you do in the salon (4–5 min)
--------	------------------	------------------------------------

Speech	a talk of 4–5 minutes	deliver it in full, from notes, with your open and close by heart
Op-ed	500–700 words for a named publication or readership	a one-minute spoken frame, then perform your two strongest paragraphs
Creative piece	500–700 words: a short story, personal essay, prose poems or a monologue	read it aloud (or an excerpt), then a 30-second craft note
Research summary	500–700 words synthesizing at least three real sources on one question	a four-minute spoken briefing from notes for an intelligent non-specialist

The integration map. Nothing here is new. The masterwork asks you to orchestrate what you have tuned separately.

Thread	Where you built it	How your piece shows it
The exact word	the mot juste, collocation (1.1, 1.3)	every key term the inevitable one, with no near-misses
Register	register agility (1.2); pragmatics (Module 2)	a tone chosen for the audience and held without a slip
Cohesion	discourse markers, coherence across long texts (3.1–3.2)	one seamless arc, not a string of parts
Rhetoric and imagery	figurative language (2.3); rhetoric (4.1)	devices deployed with purpose, and only where the thought needs them
Voice	style and voice (4.2)	unmistakably yours
Awareness	varieties, literature, media (Module 5); cultures, diplomacy, translation (Module 7)	sensitivity to audience, culture and nuance
Authority and delivery	writing with authority (Module 6); exams and public speaking (8.1–8.2)	performed with impact; the discussion fielded with composure

◆ GRAMMAR BOX – DISCUSSING AND RESPONDING

Check the question	If I've understood you, the worry is that... · Is the question really about...?
Concede, then narrow	That's a genuinely important challenge, and you're right to press it. · Let me draw the distinction I actually mean. · I'm not saying...; I'm saying... · Granted, ...; what I'm claiming is narrower: ... · I'd resist the word "..."; I'd say "..." instead.
Reflect	What landed for me was... · The phrase "... " did a great deal of work: ...

Probe	What made you choose... rather than...? · I wonder whether... · Could you say more about...?
Challenge	Someone might push back on... · How would you answer a reader who...? · Does the evidence support "...", or something narrower?
Offer	If this were mine, I might... · One thing I'd be tempted to try is...

The response protocol: quote before you judge · describe the effect · ask before you suggest · offer one change, not ten · the writer or speaker decides.

◆ EXERCISE 1 – NAME THE THREAD · WRITE

Each description shows one skill of the full range. Choose from: *mot juste* · *register* · *cohesion* · *rhetoric* · *personal voice*.

1. Choosing "impersonation" instead of "copy" because it is the one exact word: that's the _____.
2. Holding a formal-but-warm tone throughout, never slipping into slang: that's control of _____.
3. Linking every paragraph so that the whole reads as one seamless arc: that's _____.
4. Using antithesis ("known more, understood less") to make a point land: that's _____.
5. The human signature that makes the piece sound like you and no one else: that's your _____.

◆ EXERCISE 2 – PRINCIPLES OF LIFELONG COMMAND · WRITE

1. The richest source of new vocabulary and style is wide, daily _____ for pleasure.
2. You never understand something so well as when you must _____ it to someone else.
3. A mastered language is not a trophy but a _____: it grows only if you tend it.
4. The summit of C2 is not an ending but a _____ into lifelong use.

◆ EXERCISE 3 – JUDGE IT AGAINST THE C2 STANDARD · READ

A C2 descriptor says a proficient user can express themselves spontaneously, very fluently and precisely, differentiating finer shades of meaning even in complex situations. Does each snippet meet that bar? Say why in a few words.

1. "The plan was good. It worked. People liked it. It was a success." _____
2. "The plan, ambitious to the point of recklessness, succeeded in spite of itself, and won over a public that had every reason to resist it." _____
3. "Basically the plan was, like, really really good and stuff, you know?" _____
4. "Not until the second reading did the report's quiet evasions become visible, which is, I suspect, precisely what its authors intended." _____

◆ EXERCISE 4 – CONCEDE, THEN NARROW · WRITE

Each presenter either collapses or stonewalls. Rewrite the answer so that it concedes the valid part and narrows the claim.

1. Challenge: "Your op-ed says screens harm concentration. Aren't you just nostalgic for a world before phones?" Answer: "You're right. Maybe it's just nostalgia."

2. Challenge: "Your research summary relies on three studies from one country. Can you generalize?" Answer: "The studies are clear. The results apply everywhere."

3. Challenge: "Your story's ending feels too neat. Isn't real life messier?" Answer: "It's fiction. It doesn't have to be realistic."

◆ EXERCISE 5 – FROM VAGUE TO PRECISE FEEDBACK • WRITE

Rewrite each comment so that it is useful to a C2 writer or speaker: quote, describe an effect, ask, or offer one change.

1. "It was really good, well done!"

2. "Your ending was a bit weak."

3. "Too many metaphors."

4. "I didn't agree with you."

◆ DIALOGUE – A MASTERWORK AND ITS DISCUSSION • LISTEN • READ

Speaker: I've come to believe that fluency in a language is the least interesting thing about knowing it. [pause] Fluency is the door. What lies beyond it, the humor you can finally catch, the argument you can finally win on its own terms, the stranger who becomes a friend because you met them in their own words: that is the room. And I spent years, frankly, mistaking the door for the room.

Speaker: So when people ask me why anyone would climb all the way to mastery (why not stop at "good enough"?), I answer with a question of my own. Good enough for what? Good enough to be understood, yes. But not, perhaps, good enough to be moved, or to move someone else.

Discussant: That's a lovely image, but isn't there something a little elitist in it? Most people will never reach mastery, and they live perfectly rich lives in their language all the same.

Speaker: That's a genuinely important challenge, and you're right to press it; I'd hate for this to sound like a hierarchy of worth. Let me draw the distinction I actually mean. I'm not saying mastery makes a person richer; I'm saying it opens particular rooms: a poem in the original, a joke that doesn't survive translation. Those rooms aren't better than others. They're simply closed until you have the key.

Discussant: And for someone just beginning that climb, what would you say?

Speaker: That the summit they're dreading is closer than they think, and that the view, when they reach it, is not an ending but a door of its own.

1. What is the central metaphor, and what does "mistaking the door for the room" mean?

2. How does the speaker answer the charge of elitism: reject it, concede it wholesale, or something more precise? _____
3. Find one example each of precise diction, a rhetorical device and personal voice.

4. How does the final line connect to the idea of lifelong command? _____

◆ PLANNING FRAME – MY MASTERWORK • WRITE

Format	☐ speech ☐ op-ed ☐ creative piece ☐ research summary
Subject	_____
Controlling idea (one sentence)	_____
My audience or readership	_____
Shape	Opening: _____ Middle (2–4 movements): _____ Ending: _____

My range plan	☐ the exact word in the key places ☐ a register I can hold ☐ cohesion across the whole ☐ one or two devices the thought needs ☐ my own voice ☐ (research) sources attributed and hedged to their strength
The hardest question I expect	_____
What I can concede • how I will narrow	_____

◆ BEFORE YOU PRESENT – CHECKLIST

- ◆ ☐ My controlling idea is clear early (or, in a creative piece, withheld on purpose).
- ◆ ☐ I read the piece aloud and cut every word that sounded placed rather than arisen.
- ◆ ☐ No device is there for its own sake; a reader would not notice the technique before the thought.
- ◆ ☐ My register holds from the first line to the last.
- ◆ ☐ Length: _____ words, or _____ minutes (target 500–700 words, or 4–5 minutes).
- ◆ ☐ Research summary only: at least three real sources, listed at the end; no invented figures.
- ◆ ☐ One spelling system (American or British), used consistently.
- ◆ ☐ My open and close are rehearsed until they are automatic.

◆ MY LIFELONG-COMMAND PLAN • WRITE

There is no next level to climb; from here, you set the curriculum. Make each commitment specific enough that someone could ask you about it. (You may write the plan for a new identity.)

Where I am	My strongest area: _____ My growth edge: _____ Two fossilized items I will hunt down: _____
Read widely	_____
Use it where it matters	_____
Teach it	_____
Live in it	_____
A formal exam?	☐ not for me ☐ maybe later ☐ yes, because it opens this door: _____
My first step, this week	_____

In three months I will know it's working because...	_____
My accountability partner and date	_____

◆ RUBRIC SELF-CHECK – CIRCLE ONE LEVEL FOR EACH

All formats	Mastery	Secure	Developing
1 · Integration of the C2 range	many threads, woven invisibly	several threads, sometimes visible	one or two threads, or a showreel
2 · Precision & register	the exact word; tone held throughout	occasional near-misses or slips	imprecise or uneven
3 · Coherence across the whole	one seamless arc	clear, with a visible join or two	a string of parts
My format (circle): speech · op-ed · creative · research	Mastery	Secure	Developing
4 · The format's craft (delivery; argument; imagery; synthesis)	fully realized	mostly realized	not yet realized
5 · Presentation in the salon	performed, not read	partly read	read aloud or lost
The discussion	Mastery	Secure	Developing
Understanding the question	found the question behind it	answered what was asked	sometimes off target
Concede & narrow	poised and precise	sometimes defensive or yielding	collapsed or stonewalled
Composure	calm, courteous, unhurried	mostly	hurried or hesitant

My triumph: _____

What my next piece will do better: _____

◆ SELF-CHECK – CIRCLE A, B OR C

1

What is the highest skill the masterwork tests?

A) Learning a final new technique

B) Integrating the whole range into one seamless, effortless piece

C) Speaking for as long as possible

2

Now that you have reached C2, what is the path forward?

A) Move up to the next CEFR level above C2

B) Consider the language finished and stop practicing

C) Keep growing through lifelong reading, real-world use, teaching, and living in it

3

Which response to a peer's masterwork is most useful to a C2 writer?

A) "Great job, very fluent! I loved it."

B) "The garden metaphor landed for me: it made the idea of practice feel hopeful. I wonder whether the second metaphor in paragraph three competes with it. If this were mine, I might cut it."

C) A list of ten corrections, from commas to word choice

◆ I CAN...

- ◆ ☐ plan and polish a substantial piece in a format of my choice
- ◆ ☐ deploy the full C2 range and then hide the seams
- ◆ ☐ field a searching question: find the question behind it, concede, narrow
- ◆ ☐ respond to a peer's work precisely and generously
- ◆ ☐ judge my own English against the C2 standard
- ◆ ☐ commit to a specific plan for lifelong command

◆ MY FINAL JOURNAL

Write a letter to the person you were at the very beginning of your English journey, when even a sentence felt like a mountain. Tell them honestly what the climb was like, which moments nearly stopped you, and what it

feels like to stand where you stand now. Then turn the page and write your own curriculum for the years ahead: the books you'll read, the rooms you'll dare to speak in, the person you'll teach. (Your beginning may be real or imagined; share only what you choose.)